
GERMANTOWN
O L D A N D N E W

Its Rare
and Notable
Plants



1904

BY EDWIN C. JELLETT

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Title: Germantown old and new
Its rare and notable plants

Author: Edwin C. Jellett

Release date: April 6, 2026 [eBook #78370]

Language: English

Original publication: Germantown: Germantown Independent-Gazette,
1904

Other information and formats: www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/78370

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK GERMANTOWN
OLD AND NEW ***

Arranged and Printed
by the
Germantown Independent-Gazette
Germantown, Pa.



[Oak Tree and Rabbit Lane](#)

GERMANTOWN

OLD AND NEW

**Its Rare
and Notable
Plants**



1904

BY EDWIN C. JELLETT

To
CLARA HELEN BAUMANN
*a native of Germantown whose
ancestors beautified it in the
past as their successor honors
and enriches it in the present.*



PREFACE

This outline sketch of our “rare and notable plants” was prepared at the direction of “The Germantown Horticultural Society” and was read at its public meeting of May 9, 1904,—the same later appearing in the columns of the “Germantown Independent-Gazette.”

At the time of writing, there was no thought of publishing the paper, it being hurriedly assembled outside the time required for daily positive duties within the limits of one week,—and was intended only for a simple address.

This will partly explain, if it does not excuse obvious defects, and since I have been urged by several members of the Society named to present the paper in print, I have concluded to send it forth with all its faults from the same types by which it first appeared, asking only that the circumstances be remembered, for no one, I feel confident, is able to satisfactorily present the plants of Germantown in an article so brief,—or more definitely,—I am not able to do so. To the original paper I have added an index, which I hope may not be found superfluous.

For the illustrations which grace our pages, I am indebted to S. Mendelsohn Meehan,—who suggested this paper,—and to Horace F. McCann—who printed it. The faces which familiarly greet us I have added to dignify our work, for past and present they represent the “stuff” which built our town,—preserved it,—and now keep it,—forever famous. Last, but not least, I feel sure we all are pleased with the appearance of our book, and to Erwin W. Moyer, whose skill and good taste reared upon a sub-stratum apparently hopelessly unpromising a structure so creditable, I wish to record my heartiest thanks.

E. C. J.

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Prof. Thomas Meehan, a noted scientist, educator and writer, the author of the greatest books upon our native flora, and the nestor of American Horticulture. Print of "Meehans' Monthly."

GERMANTOWN RARE AND NOTABLE PLANTS

IN the presentation and consideration of our home plants of special interest, it should be kept in mind that nearly all, if not quite all, were transplanted to the positions they now occupy, and that there is here no disposition to compare or contrast with other plants of greater age, of more historic worth, our rare and notable plants of “nature” and cultivation.

Our purpose is rather to show that, with our town’s increase in girth and years, we have had a like advance in intelligence and culture, and that our old mansions, gardens and those who keep them have earned for Germantown the title,—“the most beautiful suburb in America.”

We have no yew trees 3000 years old, no oak trees of 2000 years’ growth, no “Burnham beeches,” nor have we other plants of great age equal to those of older countries and especially England, but such as we have we shall in outline endeavor to present, and direct attention to the fact that they have merited and received the attention of visitors, who have had opportunity for observation abroad. About ten years ago, George Nicholson, curator of the Royal Botanical Gardens of Kew, London, was the guest of Prof. Thomas Meehan, and spent some time here. After leaving he said:

“Germantown is a place which every foreigner interested in American trees should visit, as the people of this suburb of Philadelphia one hundred years ago were especially interested in the introduction and cultivation of rare trees, and the first cultivated specimens of several American trees were originally planted here, and may still be seen. The roads of Germantown are shaded with beautiful rows of native trees, and behind them stretch the green lawns of innumerable villas.”

John Walter, editor of the London Times, while here expressed similar views, and many other visitors and writers who passed through Germantown have left us a record of their “impressions.”

To name all our worthy plants were a hopeless task, and one which I shall not attempt. Our efforts shall be rather to trace the thread of development,

and by examples of past and present conspicuous plants to illustrate its growth. To do this properly we should go back to the settlement of the town itself, know the causes which gave it birth, understand the character of its founders and their pursuits—its growth material and intellectual, before we may be able to meet its merits with an equal appreciation.

Alway while walking along our Main street I am reminded of the popular, well-known thoroughfare of Oxford, England, which it strangely suggests, and I sometimes wonder if it was not this ancient street, and not the central highway of Philadelphia, which to our own principal thoroughfare 150 years ago gave us High street, a name by which it was long known. Be this as it may, our Main street in a very striking way resembles its more widely known namesake abroad, a highway Hawthorne described as “the noblest street in England,” and to which “Wordsworth devoted a sonnet to the stream-like windings of that glorious street.”

As I follow our “avenues” pleasing course, I am further reminded of old Edinburgh’s hallowed hill, and as I picture its steep ascent, its numerous historic buildings, its atmosphere of antiquity, I see Sir Walter Scott from his carriage strenuously discoursing upon its wealth of interests to the delight of his guests and his own apparent satisfaction, for to him Edinburgh was home, and to so entertain his friends was “very heaven,” and as I look into the future, I see our own “cannongate” of not one whit less historic value, by one as illustrious, made as widely, and as permanently known.

In olden time it was the custom to approach Germantown only by the “Great Road,” for indeed for a period there was no other way. The original survey map of Germantown, dated October 24, 1683, now in the possession of Governor Samuel W. Pennypacker, is void of side roads or lanes, but this defect immediately after the settlement was remedied, maps following showing lanes to mills, and later maps showing other roads connecting Germantown with important near-by pikes east and west. After Rittenhouse Mill road, and Roberts’ Mill road, one of the most important of later roads was Bensell’s or School House lane connecting our Main street with Ridge road, a favorite route with travelers when the quagmires and quicksands of “3-Mile Run” proved troublesome.

In a letter dated March 7, 1684, which Francis Daniel Pastorius wrote his parents, he gave them this information: "As relating to our newly laid out town Germanopolis or Germantown, it is situated on a deep and very fertile soil, and is blessed with an abundance of fine springs and fountains of fresh water. The main street is 60 feet wide, and the cross streets 40 feet in width. Each family has a plot of ground for yard and garden 3 acres in size. The air is pure and serene, the summer is longer and warmer than it is in Germany, and we are cultivating many kinds of fruits and vegetables, and our labor meets with rich reward."

The ground of which Pastorius wrote was not the immigrants' first choice, but after a difference with William Penn was selected on account of its elevation, and also because it was open ground with only here and there groups of trees. After the survey lines were established farms and gardens, and of course, houses, were located on each side of the main road, the farm boundaries extending in parallel lines from the "great road" east to Bristol township line, now Stenton avenue, and west to the Roxborough line, now Wissahickon avenue. In other respects these lines, however, were never strictly drawn, and places on York road to the east, and Roxborough on the west, were nearly always referred to as "Germantown."

The Main street farm lots began a few feet north of "Lower Burying Ground," now Hood's Cemetery, and were plotted northward in divisions of "half lots" of 115½ feet front each, or "whole lots" of 231 feet front each, to a point adjoining "Upper" or "Concord Burying Ground," located a few feet north of Kyser's, now Washington lane. The original settlers of "42 persons in 12 families" were located upon this road, for so it had been planned. In "a further account of the Province of Pennsylvania," published in 1685, wrote Penn:

"We do settle in the way of townships or villages, each of which contains 5000 acres in square, and at least 10 families; many that had right to more land were at first covetous to have their whole quantity without regard to this way of settlement, tho' by such wilderness vacancies they had ruined the country and then our interest of course. I had in my view society, assistance, busy commerce, instruction of youth, government of people, manners, conveniency of religious assembling, encouragement of mechanics, distinct and beaten roads, and it has answered in all those respects, I think, to the universal content."

Our first settlers were not tillers of the soil. Pastorius records they were “mostly linen weavers, unaccustomed to husbandry,” but “yeomen” closely followed, and soon

“The meads’ environed with the silver streames”

were planted, and by a gracious providence stimulated to transmit to us the increase. William Penn quoting Robert Turner, wrote—“the manufacturers of linnen by the Germans goes on finely, and they make fine linnen. Samuel Carpenter, having been lately there, declares they had gathered one crop of flax, and had sowed for the second and saw it come up well.”

This Samuel Carpenter was a busy resident of Philadelphia, and the holder of 500 acres of ground in the vicinity of present Branchtown.

Very early in the growth of the new colony the importance of Germantown was recognized, and although its founders were disappointed, desiring ground upon a “navigable stream,” they made the best of what they considered a poor bargain, and losing no time, they, under the direction of Pastorius, gave life and vigor to the new “town,” planted, and eight years after the settlement, Oldmixon stated, “the whole street about one mile in length was lined with blooming peach trees.” Soon the hastily constructed log cabins gave way to substantial buildings of stone, and much of the stone, I doubt not, came from the quarry of Godfried Lehman, located at what is now Main and Price streets, where the old round-house once stood. Those who remember the Heivert Papen or Jansen house, built in 1698, and which about 25 years ago was removed from the northwest corner of Main and Johnson streets, may picture the houses “built of stone which is mixed with glimmer,” observed by Peter Kalm in his visit here in 1748.

About this time the character of Germantown began to change, although this change did not become pronounced until 50 years later. An influx of settlers of means and the improved conditions of the natives created new desires, houses became larger and more elaborate, “plantations” or “estates” began to take the place of farms, trade stimulated by wealth became of more importance, and the commingling of commerce and culture gave to Germantown an atmosphere not enjoyed by those who planted the settlement.

With the advent and accumulation of gain came those luxuries which only wealth and culture are able to accommodate, and the severe simplicity of those who for conscience sake, left the Fatherland to aid in the “holy experiment” and found a commonwealth, slowly gave way to an expanding era of change.

There were writers of this period who give us other impressions. One of the most unsympathetic of these was Silas Deane, who in 1775 wrote:

“Germantown consists of one street built mostly of rough stone, two miles nearly in length, and the houses resemble the appearance of the inhabitants, rough children of nature, and German nature too.” This writer doubtless was an ancestral connection of Lewis Carroll, who, in “Hunting of the Snark,” wrote,

“The crew was Dutch,
and behaved as such.”

But though rather uncomplimentary, Deane’s account is extremely interesting, and as Townsend Ward reports him, is as follows:

“The greatest improvement on nature is that on their groves, owing by no means to luxury, but to penury and want. The growth is red oak (*quercus rubra*), interspersed with black walnut (*juglans nigra*), etc. The poor are allowed to cut up the brush and trim the lower limbs; this leaves the groves in the most beautiful order you can imagine. All is clean on the ground; removing every shrub and bush, leaves the wind full play to sweep the floor, and the soil, by no means luxuriant, shooting up the trees rather sparingly, so much grass starts as to give a pale green carpet; while the trees are trimmed up ten to fifteen feet on their trunks, and give the eye a prospect far into the grove, and the footman or horseman free access.”

As we may readily imagine, the original Germantown settlers were a busy people, so with the exception of Pastorius, Godfried Lehman, and a few others, we have little from them, and for our information we are obliged to depend upon visiting travelers. Ten years before the time of Deane’s report Major Robert Rogers wrote thus of Philadelphia:

“In short, scarce anything can afford a more beautiful landscape than this city and adjacent country, which for some miles may be compared to a well

regulated, flourishing garden, being improved, as I have been informed, to as great advantage as almost any lands in Europe.”

In 1799 Duke de la Rochefoucault described Germantown as “a long village near 2½ miles in extent. The houses to the number of about 300 are all built on the side of the highway, and are erected pretty close to each other.”

Of the planting of the people he wrote:

“They raise a good deal of wheat, and still more Indian corn, but very little rye or oats.”

Rev. John C. Ogden, who visited here in the same year, describes the village in much the same way, and noted, “the road is muddy and dusty when rains or droughts prevail. The houses in Germantown are very universally shaded with weeping willows, the Lombardy poplar, and other ornamental trees. The gardens are under excellent cultivation, with valuable fields in their rear.”

Several visitors of importance we shall pass, for the purpose is merely to expose the line of continuity to enable us to form a better idea of the floral life of old Germantown, and with a recollection of Edward H. Bonsall, who, as Rev. S. F. Hotchkin reports, lived here from 1819 to 1835, we will turn aside into another path. Evidently the last-named was a poor observer, for he said, “in a circle of six miles with Chew’s house as a centre outside of Main street, there would not have been found 5 houses superior to an ordinary farm house,” a statement so absurd as to require no consideration.

This brings us to days which Robert Thomas and Joseph Murter, venerable residents living with us, remember, and we shall now endeavor to follow the development of our many fine estates enriched by mansions, gardens, rare shrubs and notable trees, and with these note as much as we possess or remember of data and lore as may give promise of interest.

To me it is extremely interesting that original holdings are yet held by families whose ancestors first occupied them, and I doubt if there be another settlement in America where uninterruptedly so many generations have occupied the same ground. Names which come readily to mind are Pastorius, Logan, Rittenhouse, Johnson, Keyser, and a group of other names of early settlers represented by the Wisters. Yet we have with us “Wyck,” its original house built by Hans Millan its original settler, standing surrounded

by its original garden, and its occupant and owner, Miss Jane R. Haines, a direct descendant of its first owner—a house whose only local competitor for age with the possible exceptions of Rock-House, and Naglee's Houses, is the "Fraley House," clearly of later construction, which stands in what was once Dr. Christopher Witt's garden, later Miss Elizabeth C. Morris' garden, situated at the southeast corner of Main and High streets, a building which may be seen to the rear of Mrs. Farnum's charming latticed residence.

Local history, to me at least, is always alluring, and it is with difficulty that I hew to the proper line, the temptation being to venture a little more. But we shall leave Dr. Witt and these pleasant shades to follow in the footsteps of others perhaps less well known.



Morris Littell House

By an unwritten law, observed from the days of Godfried Lehman to those of Charles F. Jenkins, our latest guide, Germantown has been approached from the south by way of Main street, and a custom so honored I hope not to be the first to disturb. Many of us, indeed most of us, I think, are able to

recall Germantown village of 2½ miles or more, when the large buttonwood tree (*platanus occidentalis*) at Naglee's house stood entire, shading on late afternoons "Turnpike Bridge" near; when horse-cars, ignoring schedule, halted at the temporarily deserted tree at the fork, in waiting for "Jake," who was somewhere out of sight northward on the hill, and no more in a hurry than those in the car, who looked upon as an unwarranted innovation a noisy train which passed to disturb their restful meditations; when laden wagons unfortunate jumped the track, seriously interfering with suburban traffic; when on "market days" long lines of wagons laden with hay, straw and other commodities numerous, twice a week struggled through and oft-times blocked the busy road. Time was, and that not long ago, when Charles J. Wister, the well-known beloved father of Grumblethorpe's present owner, under the shade of his street trees, dined upon the sidewalk, with none to wonder nor molest; and Conestogas with other vehicles numerous, which James Stokes records, passed and re-passed as naturally as present day trolleys, to whose inveterate clash and bang we have become accustomed. Those were the days when gardening was a pleasure if not an "art," and the planting of the good old plain gardeners, who never dreamed their calling would be elevated to a "science," is before us to judge.

At the house of Isaac Norris, until a generation ago standing on Germantown road, near Tenth street, and widely known as "Fairhill," was one of the finest gardens in the colonies. This garden was of the formal type, and "Francis Daniel Pastorius, of Germantown, himself a man of taste, pronounced Fair-hill garden the finest he had seen in the whole country,"—so wrote Thompson Westcott in "Historic Mansions" of Philadelphia, and this same writer continues: "Some of the trees and plants came from France. There were catalpas from the Southern States, and it was here were grown the first willow trees (*salix alba*) in Pennsylvania, the introduction of which is told by Franklin in his account of noticing the sprouting of a willow which had been used in a basket which he saw on board a ship which came to a wharf on the Delaware. Franklin took the sprout, and presented it to Debby Norris, who planted it, where it became the parent of many trees of the same species which have since become so common."

There are many white willow trees about Germantown, two fine specimens each with trunks 4 feet in diameter by 70 feet in height, being located on East Coulter street, corner of Cumberland street; but nearly all our best

weeping willows (*salix babylonica*) have disappeared. Now no vestige remains of the rows of willows which lined both sides of Church lane, east of Willow avenue, notable trees which Thomas MacKellar described for Rev. S. F. Hotchkin. Under one of these trees, which stood prominently in the middle of the road, tradition says General Washington was accustomed to spend an evening hour in its shade. There yet remains to us, however, interesting willows near the entrance to Vernon, at Wyck, and several large and beautiful specimens are on the estate of Charles Weiss, East Washington lane, near Stenton avenue.

As you may remember, the weeping willow is a native of China, and by the Dutch was introduced to Holland. By these same people it was also introduced to England, one of the first specimens in that country being planted at Hampton Court.

Advancing northward by way of York road, we note on the grounds of J. Bertram Lippincott a fine white oak (*quercus alba*) with a trunk four feet in diameter and rising to a height of 80 feet. Here also is a specially fine white pine (*pinus strobus*), but there is hardly a place of importance in or near Germantown where there are not conspicuous, if not great, white pine trees. It is a characteristic of a white pine that it dominates wherever it is, and a plant which at a distance appears to be of great proportions, near is found to be disappointingly ordinary.

From "Solitude," located east of York road, south of Fisher's lane, the best plants have disappeared. There yet, however, is a catalpa (*catalpa bignonioides*), having a trunk three feet in diameter and a height of forty feet; a chestnut (*castanea vesca*), with a trunk of five feet in diameter and a height of 70 feet; a tulip poplar (*liriodendron tulipifera*), 4 feet in diameter and 100 feet in height; and a finely proportioned walnut (*juglans nigra*), 3 feet in diameter and 80 feet high.

These trees are surpassed by others elsewhere, the walnut in particular being excelled by like trees on Morton street near High street, on Main street above Tulpehocken street, at Nutwold on East Johnson street,—all superior plants, and by a wide branching tree of the same species overspreading a spring-house on the grounds of Frank Smyth, Washington lane, east of Chew street, a specimen 6 feet in diameter and 90 feet high, I think by all odds the finest in Germantown.

On Fisher's lane east of York road is an exceedingly fine white poplar (*populus alba*), having a trunk 48 inches in diameter and a height of 80 feet; and farther east on the same lane, with its lands bordering those of "York Farm,"—the last American home of Fanny Kemble,—is Champlost, a beautiful estate occupied by Miss Fox, where grow some of our finest plants,—but it being situated beyond our proper limits, we shall with this mention pass it, to stop at a worthy neighbor.

Bordering York road, above Logan Station, is "Clearfield," now "Fairfield," a plantation which Henry Drinker purchased in 1794, and so named because "James Fisher has a place that has been called 'Newington' for many years, 'twas thought best to change the name," wrote Elizabeth Drinker in her entertaining "journal."

This plantation or farm was held for two years by the Drinkers, its mistress delighting in its occupation and rewards, recording its cherries ripe May 17; describing an odd tulip (*tulipa gesneriana*), which grew in its garden, a plant "with 8 leaves, which I look upon as a curiosity, never having seen one before with more than 6 leaves," and continuing she noted, "a very beautiful place it is, how delighted and pleased would many women be with such a retreat."

The beauty of Clearfield was appreciated by successive owners and care was taken for its preservation. Although a railroad has cut the place in sections, and its collections are depleted, it yet preserves sufficient of merit to attract the most superficial plant observer. Here at the old mile-stone—"2 M. to R. S., 4 M. to P."—surrounded by high trees and ivy-covered, is its secluded mansion, which one approaches by box (*buxus sempervirens*) bordered walks, winding between borders of heavy shrubbery, and about are several conspicuous hemlock (*tsuga canadensis*), beech (*fagus ferruginea*), and button-ball (*plantanus occidentalis*) trees.

Near the upper entrance gate is a white pine, and beside the house a Norway spruce (*picea excelsa*), both of strange development, and as odd as any of the grotesque growths I have seen at Wildwood, N. J., and elsewhere on the Atlantic coast.

Here also is a curious Austrian pine (*pinus Austriaca*), with a depressed crown; an unusually fine specimen of Himalayan pine (*pinus excelsa*), 50 feet in height, second only to pines of the same species at William Rotch

Wister's, Wisteria avenue; at Justus Strawbridge's, School House lane and Wissahickon avenue, and at Caspar Heft's, Main street, near Manheim street, the latter a specimen which George Redles considers the best in our territory.



[George Redles](#)

At "Fairfield" is a fine specimen of rare Japan cedar or cryptomeria (*cryptomeria japonica*), the acknowledged "queen of evergreens," 25 feet in height; also a fine white oak (*quercus alba*), 80 feet in height; a white or silver birch (*betula alba*), 40 feet in height, the latter a fine plant, but not equal to specimens at Fern-hill and at E. W. Clark's, Wissahickon avenue and School House lane. Also here, as reported by Philip C. Garrett, the present occupant of Fairfield, for Mrs. Anne DeB. Mears—"over the upper spring-house is an ancient and famous catalpa tree pictured in the horticultural journals, which still bears its beautiful crop of blossoms every year," a tree yet vigorous, and near the mansion, between it and the road, is a fine cedar of Lebanon (*cedrus libani*), 50 feet in height. All these plants are prominent, and may be plainly seen from the road.

“Stenton,” once extending from Fisher’s lane to Nicetown lane, from Germantown road to York road, and situated from “Fairfield” to the west, has been shorn of much of its wealth. A. J. Downing, who visited it, thus describes it in “Landscape Gardening” of 1849: “Stenton, near Germantown, four miles from Philadelphia, is a fine old place, with many picturesque features. The farm consists of 700 acres, almost without division fences—admirably arranged—and remarkable for a grand old avenue of the hemlock spruce (*abies canadensis*), 110 years old, leading to a family cemetery of much sylvan beauty.”

This same “splendid avenue of hemlocks,” described later by Townsend Ward, is no more, and of interest at Stenton now is but a tulip poplar, a large plane tree (*platanus occidentalis*), a few persimmon trees (*diospyrus virginiana*) and a row of Lombardy poplars (*populus dilatata*), plants surpassed by many with us, and by two plants of exceptional merit, one a wide-spreading black walnut (*juglans nigra*), appearing to the south of the mansion, and the other a notable elm (*ulmus Americana*), having a trunk 4 feet in diameter and a top spreading at a height of 120 feet, a plant which on part of Stenton grounds disposed of, may now be seen in the yard of Dr. William H. Hickok, northeast corner of Eighteenth and Cayuga streets, a magnificent specimen said to have been mature in the days of James Logan and William Penn.

Near-by and north of Stenton is “The Cedars,” a green grove wherein Professor Stewardson Brown long dwelt, and where this gentleman informed me is a fine specimen of swamp magnolia (*magnolia glauca*), two rare yellow-flowering magnolias (*magnolia fraseri*), a lemon-scented variety of great beauty, by many considered our finest magnolia, and a small tree of the always rare cedar of Lebanon. Here also are several fine specimens of swamp cypress (*taxodium distichium*), familiarly known about Philadelphia as Bartram’s cypress.

Without exception, the finest grove of trees in Germantown is that in the midst of which “Wakefield,” a near neighbor of Stenton and Fairfield, is situated—a grove composed of immense juniper (*juniperus virginiana*), chestnut (*castanea Americana*), white oak (*quercus alba*), red oak (*quercus rubra*), and tulip poplar (*liriodendron tulipifera*) trees. Here is a green-flowering cucumber tree (*magnolia acuminata*), perfectly proportioned, having a trunk 2 feet in diameter and a height of 30 feet. Also here on the

front lawn is a tulip poplar, measured by John Warr and George Redles, a tree 5 feet in diameter, ivy-covered from the ground to its first limb at 40 feet, and rising to a height of 130 feet, a noble specimen equal to celebrated relatives growing on the Virginian mountains, where the species is said to attain its greatest development; truly a tree, especially when in bloom, deserving Benjamin Franklin's designation—"King of the American forests."



Wakefield

Passing for the present "Little Wakefield," we halt in lower Fisher's lane to note a most interesting white oak (*quercus alba*), long familiar to me, but which I overlooked until directed again to it by George Redles. This is a rugged tree 4 feet in diameter and 60 feet high, perfectly formed, and growing on the top of a rock it has cleft in twain.

William E. S. Baker, in "Widow Seymour," accurately locates this tree "between the Wakefield mills in Fisher's Hollow, close by the bank of the Wingohocken creek, and at the curve of the lane." "The immense flat-rock" which supports this tree is also associated with "Widow Seymour," and

those of a poetic temperament may here find much of interest. Advancing to the elevation at Stenton avenue and Fisher's lane, we find before us at Mrs. M. H. Stiver's two of our finest trees, one a white oak, the other a red oak, each 4 feet in diameter and 80 feet high; both plants perfectly shaped, and with huge wide-spreading limbs, covering an area equal to their height.

Other fine specimens of oak we have are a group of three fine white oaks at Old Oaks Cemetery on Wissahickon avenue; a red oak at Stewart A. Jellett's "One Oak," Pulaski avenue, near Apsley street; a beautiful tree on the grounds of Francis B. Reeves, Clapier street and McKean avenue; our most striking and picturesque oak at Judge F. Carroll Brewster's, Manheim street, near Wissahickon avenue; a great white oak at Ivy Hill Cemetery, near Pennsylvania Railroad, a single finely developed specimen 5 feet in diameter and 100 feet high; and if not the largest, one of the finest, and certainly our most interesting oak planted by John Wister in 1803, and now adorning Vernon Park.

There are several fine trees on Fisher's lane, but we shall now stop only at T. Charlton Henry's place, where Alexander Lawson was long gardener, to record a century plant (*agave Americana*), which here bloomed a few years ago.

Retracing our steps through Wister's woods, we pass a declivity on which once grew a celebrated memorial beech. This tree stood to the north of Fisher's lane and Wakefield street, and through age and abuse came to its end in the year 1870. The Germantown Telegraph, January 29 of the named year, gave an account of this venerable and venerated tree. Near the earth its trunk was 3 feet in diameter, and "many very ancient scars and markings were on its surface, and among them within an escutcheon, deeply engraved and quite legible, were the initials D. L. W., 1771," cut there by Daniel and Lowry Wister. It is a pleasure to note that this interesting work has been preserved, and is now among the treasures of "Grumblethorpe."

Continuing through Wister's wood, a place where its late owner loved to roam, we note near the upper spring an odd twin growth, to which Charles T. Macarthur, superintendent of the Germantown Gas Works near by, directed my attention. Here are two trees, one a red oak and the other a tulip poplar, which for several feet together grow as one, resembling a unity of

two species, I discovered growing on Dark Run lane, near the Asylum pike, some years ago.

Following the Wingohocken Valley southward we round the point to “Mill” or “Valley creek,” and on our left find “Little Wakefield,” the home of Ellicott Fisher, where a number of chestnut, butternut and tulip poplar trees of fair proportions may be observed, but not any of which are equal to the lofty vigorous specimens appearing on “Wakefield’s” bank to the right, where sturdy oaks, not observable from the front, here impressively stand. “Belfield Homestead, with its famous coffee tree and lovely boulevard of maples,” now appears before us a perfect haven of rest, its most prominent plants thus referred to by W. E. S. Baker, standing conspicuous above a bordering wealth of vegetation.

From the valley we turn into Thorp’s lane, once a gem of rural beauty, but now sadly changed, to view a beautiful avenue of silver maples (*Acer dasycarpum*) extending from the main entrance to the mansion where Fanny Kemble wrote “My children were born, by first and only American home.” In “Records of Later Life” the same gifted author, under date of 1837, notes: “The other day, for the first time, I explored my small future domain, which is bounded on the right by the high road, on the left by a not unromantic little mill-stream with bits of rock, and cedar bushes, and dams, and, I am sorry to say, a very picturesque, half-tumbled-down factory; on the north by fields and orchards of our neighbors, and another road; and on the south by a pretty, deep, shady lane, running from the high road to the above-mentioned factory. There are four pretty pasture meadows, and a very pretty piece of woodland, which coasting the stream and mill-dam, will, I foresee, become a favorite haunt of mine.”

“The Farm” or “Butler Place” yet contains many notable plants, though the “row of old acacia trees near the house” was removed, and “a double row of 200 trees planted along the side of the place” show wear. The latter, however, is of great interest to us, for in spite of an acknowledged “combined ignorance” a majority of these plants have lived, and from “York Farm” in 1874 Fanny Kemble wrote: “The trees I planted along the low enclosure hedge of Butler Place, 30 years ago, stretch their branches and throw their shadows half over the road which divides the places.”

Though exceedingly pleasurable, we may not linger here too long, and to all interested in Germantown and its associations, I suggest the reading of "Records of Later Life" and "Further Records," both books of great interest, and mainly produced at "Butler Place" and "York Farm."

There are many avenues of silver maples (*acer dasycarpum*) worthy of record with us, among them being one in Town Hall Park, another at the Pulaski avenue approach to "Fern-hill," and also that leading to the Pinckney homestead, where Judge William D. Kelly once lived.

Other striking maple-lined avenues may be seen at Justus C. Strawbridge's, School House lane and Wissahickon avenue; at Samuel Welsh's, West School House lane, both of great beauty; also that of Garrett's Hill on our main street, with others numerous; and on Norwood avenue, extending from Chestnut avenue to Sunset avenue, Chestnut Hill, is one beyond compare. At Butler Place the hemlock (*tsuga canadensis*) hedge continues of more than ordinary merit, but it is surpassed by a notable hedge of the same species at Thomas P. Galvin's grounds, West Walnut lane, and by the remarkable hedges of "Fern-hill." Other plants at Butler Place worthy of notice are a black walnut and a coffee tree, both of immense size and majestic proportions. Distributed throughout our territory are many large and beautiful coffee trees (*gymnocladus canadensis*). One of these may be seen at Dr. I. Pearson Willit's, on West Walnut lane; another holds its place in Vernon Park; and a specially fine specimen stands before the Welsh mansion at Spring-Bank.

At Dr. George De Benneville's "Silver Pine Farm" is a group of white pine (*pinus strobus*), which if not the largest is at least the most imposing one among us. These trees are nine in number, are about two feet in diameter trunk, rise to a height of from 80 to 100 feet, and their shattered arms are familiar to every frequenter of Branchtown by way of Green lane or York road. As these trees gave name to the place, so we may refer to a farm house-like structure which once stood where Masonic Hall now stands on Main street near St. Luke's Church, a house in 1832 the home of Bronson Alcott, and the birthplace of Louisa M. Alcott—which from a group of trees before it, became known as "Silver Pine Cottage."

In this same cottage, while rector of St. Luke's Church, Rev. B. Wistar Morris also dwelt, and this in a measure may account for his love of

“Oregon pines,” though his old-time neighbors say he was elected bishop for quite another reason.

Conspicuous specimens of white pine, in some respects our most impressive tree, may be seen at Loudoun, at Toland’s, at Henry’s, all near Naglee’s Hill; at Fern-hill, at George Blight’s and Dr. James Gardette’s on Wissahickon avenue; at Manheim, where there is a beautiful tree three feet in diameter and 90 feet high; at Carlton on Indian Queen lane; at Armstrong’s on Duy’s lane, and at almost every place on School House lane from John Alburger’s, near Greene street, to William Weightman’s, near the “Falls;” at Jacob A. Datz’s, Stenton avenue and Mill street, and at Alfred Williams’, near by; at Old School, County line and Limekiln pike; at Vollmer’s, Washington lane; at Upsala and Lutheran Seminary—indeed, so many and so generally distributed are these beautiful plants that it is needless to further enumerate.

At Butler Place is an odd white pine, which curiously at a height of 40 feet had its terminal bud destroyed, the result being the development of a trinity of side buds. In like manner there is also a remarkable specimen at Philip Guckes’ on West School House lane, a tree 2½ feet in diameter by 70 feet high. This tree’s terminal bud at 40 feet elevation having been destroyed, two side shoots were developed, which each sturdily rose to an additional height of 30 feet.

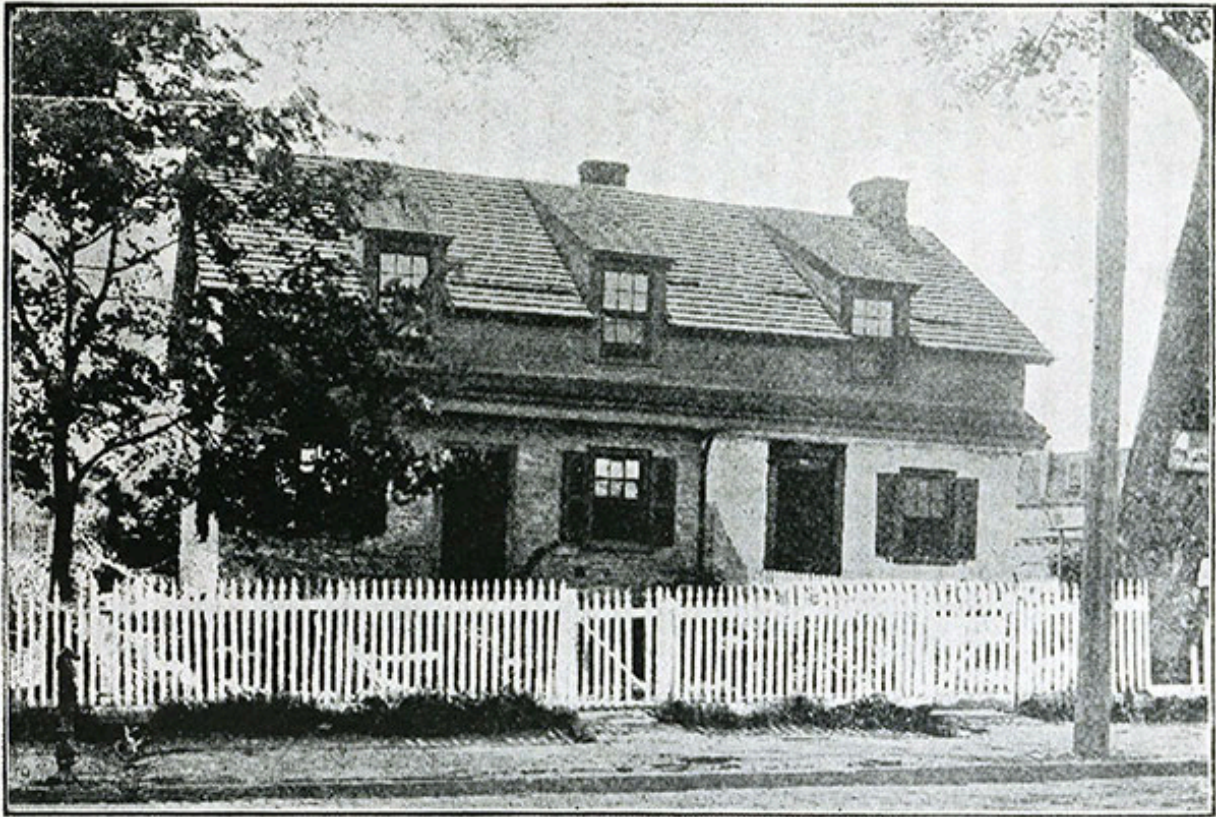
Without exception, the finest and most perfect white pine in our district is a plant growing on a knoll on “Perot’s Farm,” now Northwood Cemetery. This tree has a trunk 2½ feet in diameter, rises to a height of 70 feet, has a spread of 40 feet, and is vigorous, perfect and very beautiful.

At “Outalauna,” the residence of Joseph Wharton, is an exceedingly fine silver poplar (*populus alba*), and near at “Bonnental Cottage,” the home of Mrs. Anne de Benneville Mears, are two immense buttonwood trees (*platanus occidentalis*) with trunks 4 feet in diameter, each with a height of 100 feet, and 40 feet spread. In “Old York Road,” Mrs. Mears, writing of “Bonnental Cottage,” states “it was surrounded by a fine lawn and in front still stands one of the sycamore trees whose age is over 300 years, and its companion was planted by Dr. George De Benneville, Sr., in 1768.”

With us continue many notable buttonwood trees, although all our home trees are inferior to specimens growing in more favorable locations. In

Case's Botanical Index, Page 46, there was recorded in 1880 a buttonwood tree growing in Greene county, Indiana, having a trunk 16 feet in diameter, and which rose with a clear trunk 25 feet, the altitude reached being 160 feet, and plane trees much greater than this are known.

It would be futile to name all our worthy specimens, so I shall without mention pass many to locate a few which more directly appeal to us. We all may remember the buttonwood tree within the gate to our "Earthly Paradise," and whose denuded trunk stands to remind us of days when settlers first took up ground on "side land lots." Here with an additional story of recent growth is Naglee's house, where James Logan for a season dwelt, a building like the "Rock House," a venerable survivor and typical representative of the stone houses of early Germantown.



[Naglee Houses](#)

Recently we have lost one of two well-known sycamore trees at Wagner's, and the tree continuing is but a reminder of its former greatness. Another interesting specimen on Main street is that on the grounds of William Heft, a tree 5½ feet in diameter and 80 feet high, one of the trees which changed

the name of a public house once here from “Ye Roebuck Inn” to “Buttonwood Hotel.” Though often so asserted by over-zealous loyalists, these trees were not planted “by Philadelphia’s first mayor,” but by Andrew Garret, who carried them from the banks of the Schuylkill, and here set them in place, as “The Guide” some years ago instructed us. Andrew Garret may be remembered as an eccentric character, who during the latter part of the eighteenth century had a dwelling on Indian Queen lane, near the “Falls.” Here he lived alone, and by robbers was one night foully murdered, a sufficient warning, let us hope, to all of like preferment.

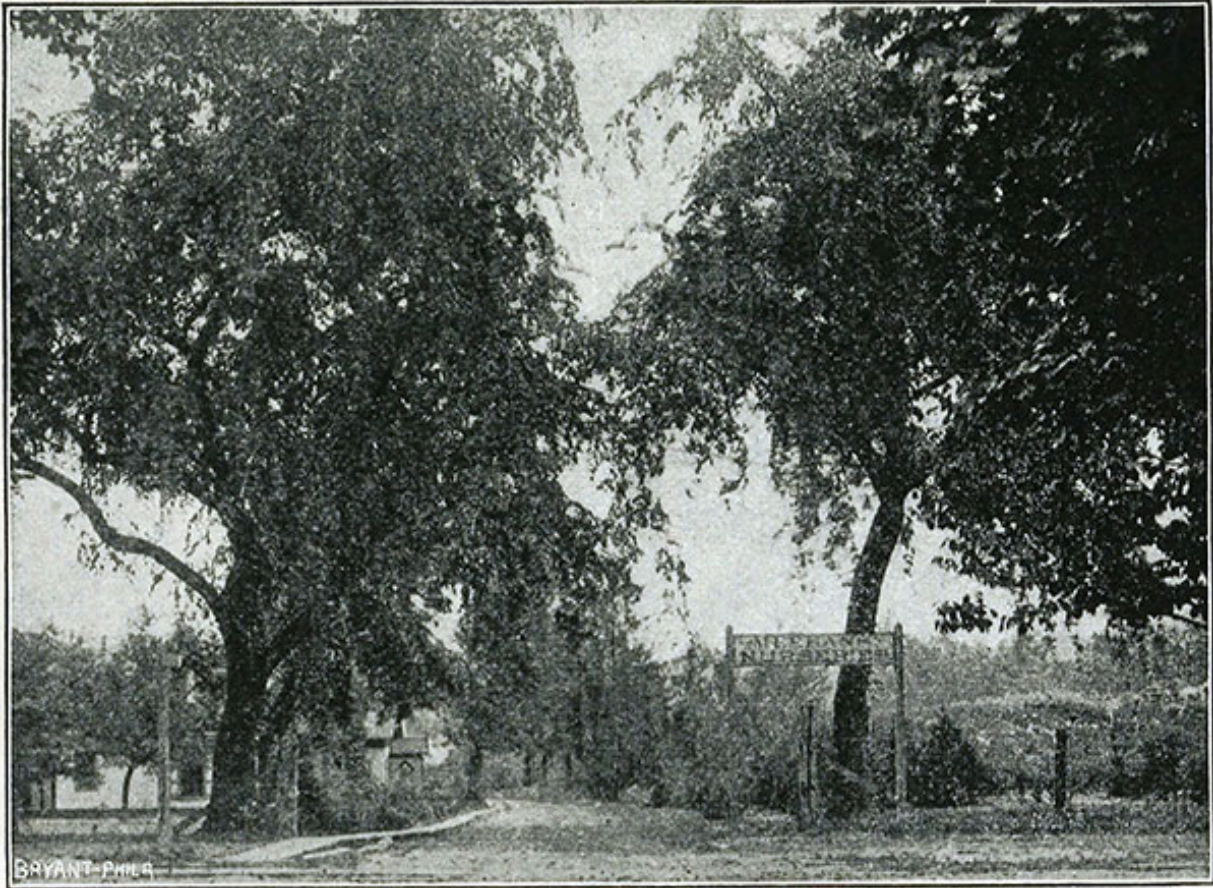
Other interesting buttonwood trees are located at the pump on Manheim street, where there is a specimen 4 feet in diameter by 80 feet high; at Manheim, near the club house, where is an odd-shaped specimen with a short trunk 4 feet in diameter, and awkwardly branching limbs rising to a height of 100 feet; at Friends’ grounds on Main street, where is a rare tree 4 feet in diameter by 60 feet high, and another specimen at Market Square, now only of interest because it was planted by Samuel B. Morris; at Dr. Ashton’s on West School House lane, where there is a majestic tree, and several others worthy a visit are in this immediate neighborhood. Rare specimens may also be seen at spring-house on Cresheim road, above Allen’s lane; at William Dewees spring-house at the bend in the upper Wissahickon, where grow two fine specimens; at “Spring Bank,” the residence of John Welsh, where is a perfect plant, 4 feet in diameter and 100 feet high; and two trees in Wissahickon avenue, near “Fern-hill” entrance, one 6 feet in diameter, 100 feet rise, with a spread of 80 feet, and the other about its equal, are the finest plane trees we have.

At National Cemetery, Haines street and Limekiln pike, are many beautiful trees, though but few of unusual size or rarity. Here are fair specimens of ginko (*salisburia adiantifolia*), but not equal to the ginkos of Edward Hacker, Wister street; Charles J. Wister, Main street; Lloyd Mifflin, Penn street; Benjamin H. Shoemaker, Mill street; and that of Alfred C. Harrison, at Thorpe’s lane, Chestnut Hill. Larch (*larix Americana*), but surpassed by the larch of David Pancoast at High and Baynton streets, by that of “Fairfield,” of “Upsala,” and several others. Silver birch and other trees of superior merit are here, and also here is a fine white pine, while in sight is a number of specimens of the same species at Middleton’s on Limekiln pike. Among the best plants at National Cemetery is an arbor vitae (*thuja*

occidentalis) group of 12 feet in diameter spread and a 30-feet height, and an exceedingly fine specimen of *retinospora plumosa*.

At one time there were several fine trees on Christopher Ludwig's farm, Haines street, near Chew street, but the best of these have disappeared, and there now remains but mediocre plane and walnut trees to halt us at the house of Washington's doughty baker general, who spent here several years of his honest life, and who from his "labors" rests in St. Michael's Lutheran Churchyard. Opposite "Ludwig Farm" is "Awbury," containing the homes of John S. Haines, Thomas P. Cope, Francis R. Cope and other members of well-known families of like name, where are many rare and beautiful plants. From "High Street Station" which was, there extended to the Cope houses a rustic walk shaded by a double row of silver maples, and this shortened continues to remind one of the celebrated "walks" of Addison at Oxford and Milton at Cambridge. Shielding Haines street, east of Chew street, is a row of specially fine scarlet maple (*acer rubrum*) trees now in bloom, and at "John Haines' gate" grow two fine elm trees, each having a trunk 2½ feet in diameter, a height of 60 feet and a spread of 80 feet, entirely covering the entrance to this most inviting place.

With us are several fine elm trees (*ulmus Americana*), one being on the grounds of Charles Edward Pancoast, East Johnson street; another is in the "Concord graveyard," and two very beautiful weeping elms of the Galena type on Chew street, opposite Church street, shade the entrance to Meehans' nurseries.



Weeping Elms

At one time several of our largest trees were to be found at Old Oaks Cemetery, grounds once a part of John Tucker's "plantation." This burying ground was located on Township Line road, and extended from near the toll-gate at McKean's hill to the railroad, south. Here was a number of immense chestnut trees, but the finest have been destroyed. Our best, however, did not class with trees elsewhere. At Hereford, Bucks county, Pa., there is, or was, standing on the farm of James Schlegel a chestnut tree $8\frac{3}{4}$ feet in diameter, 90 feet high, and said to be 200 years old. At James A. Wright's place on Township Line road, near Clapier street, is an imposing grove of great chestnut, silver maple and oak trees; at "Carlton," Indian Queen lane, is a number of chestnut trees of immense girth, but of no great height, storm riven and impressive; but perhaps our largest chestnut trees are located on the grounds of Thomas P. C. Stokes and Dr. George Strawbridge, Wissahickon avenue, near Frank street.

“Fernhill,” which from “Old Oaks” appears on an elevation before us, is slowly but surely losing its choicest plants, and during a recent visit there with George Redles, John F. Sibson, its efficient manager, attributed its losses to noxious gases proceeding from the steel works near by. Here, in addition to plants previously noted, are superior specimens of barberry (*berberis vulgaris*), weeping dog-wood (*cornus* F. variety *pendula*), common beech (*fagus ferruginea*), a fine specimen of Virginian fringe tree (*chionanthus Virginica*), and a larch of perfect proportions, 2 feet in diameter and 40 feet high. To compare with these, along Wingohocken creek, immediately north of the “Rocky Mountains” in Meehans’ nurseries, is a grove of fringe trees very beautiful when in flower, and at Manheim there is a magnificent larch, 2 feet in diameter of trunk, rising to a height of 80 feet.

The finest larch in Germantown once stood on the grounds of Hugh McLean, corner of Carpenter lane and Cresheim road, but this great tree a few years ago unfortunately met its fate.

At Thomas Jones’, Manheim street and Wissahickon avenue, is a holly (*ilex opaca*) 15 feet high, with a spread of 15 feet, a beautiful specimen, but equaled by two notable plants at Vernon, and surpassed by Wister Price’s specimen on Manheim grounds, a tree having a trunk 1½ feet in diameter, 25 feet high, with a branch spread of 20 feet. Here also is a rare *virgilia*, the first, and once the finest specimen in cultivation,—a tree now showing the ravages of old age, but none the less interesting. A *virgilia* younger (*cladrastis tinctoria*), vigorous and beautiful, overhangs the gate of “Grumblethorpe,” Main street, opposite Queen street, and is the best of its species I know in our territory.

The charms of “Caernarvon” have flown, but Manheim possesses a beauty of its own, one of its many attractions being the finest group of rhododendrons (*rhododendron maximum*) in Germantown. The neighborhood of Manheim to me is of great interest, but we may not stop to consider its historic associations nor to refer to all its plants worthy of notice.

By far the finest silver maple in Germantown stood on the grounds of Louis Clapier Baumann, at corner of Manheim and Henry streets. This fine tree some years ago I measured, and when it was felled to make way for

improvements these measurements were verified by John Holt. The tree was perfect in every particular, of commanding height, and was a notable landmark of Manheim street. An account of this plant I prepared for "Forest Leaves," of June, 1897, wherein it is described as being 138 feet in height. At half its altitude it had a spread of 35 feet on every side of the main trunk, and at 1 foot above the ground the trunk was $4\frac{1}{3}$ feet in diameter.



[L. C. Baumann](#)

We have many fine specimens of silver maple continuing, and one of the finest stands on Cresheim road, near Gorgas street. Another appears to the rear of Dr. John D. Godman's house, Main street, opposite Pastorius street. Another, and a very striking one, stands at the corner of West Walnut lane and Adams street, but this tree a few years ago was visited by marauders and now it is but a relic of its former greatness. At "The Corvy," the residence of William Wynne Wister, there are several silver maples, not specially great, but of interest because they are directly on Main street and shade Gilbert Stuart's house.

It is recorded that Jacques Marie Roset, who lived on the upper side of Manheim street, adjoining James R. Gates' lumber yard, and not at "Spring Alley," as has oft been reported, had a beautiful garden, the products of which it is said he loved to distribute, one of his recipients being Fanny Kemble, who from her home on York road frequently passed this way on driving trips, a recreation she always loved. It is also recorded that Roset first introduced tomatoes to Germantown, but this does not appear to be correct, for the credit belongs, I think, to E. B. Gardette, whose place on Wissahickon avenue, opposite Manheim street, is marked by three notable pine trees rising to a height of 80 feet.

This gentleman came to America during the Revolutionary period, and it is said his gardener first grew the tomato (*lycopersicum esculentum*), or love apple, for the color of its fruit. Melons or canteloupes were also first raised here, it has been stated, but this I have never been able to verify, "for the seed of the canteloupe was brought to this country from Tripoli, and distributed by Commodore James Barron," so I give the credit for what it is worth.

This, however, I know, Philip R. Freas, a neighbor of Commodore Barron, had a canteloupe patch which the "brickyard" boys well knew, and about it I doubt not Philip Walters, and George Redles—who having reached years of discrimination, has now no need to ask if it be "true that horses when old never lie down"—can tell you more than I.

Baumann's great maple grew on ground which once belonged to "White Cottage," an estate at one time owned by the Logans. Here lived Dr. Samuel Betton, who was succeeded by his son, Dr. Thomas Forrest Betton, the friend of Rafinesque, and here under Samuel Betton, its present occupant and owner, William Kulp, well known to many of us, has been many years gardener. Recent changes have robbed "White Cottage" of its seclusion, but with it yet continue many beautiful ivy-dressed trees, which spread their branches over the grounds, in season almost shielding the house from view.

Near General Wayne Hotel, on Manheim street, is a specially fine ailanthus (*ailanthus glandulosus*) 2½ feet in diameter of trunk, with a height of 50 feet, and at the Keyser-Rodney House, Main and Duval streets, and on Garrett's Hill, opposite Lovett Library are conspicuous superior specimens. Also on Manheim street, near Main street, is a honey-locust tree

(*Gleditsia triacanthos*) with a trunk 3 feet in diameter by 80 feet high, and larger and finer specimens are on Pulaski avenue, near Seymour street, and in front of Michael Schlatter's stone house, Main street, near where the road turns off for "Wheel Pump," Chestnut Hill.

At "Carlton" is a magnificent beech (*Fagus ferruginea*) 3 feet in diameter of trunk, with a height of 60 feet and a spread of 40 feet, the finest specimen I know in our territory. We have many fine beeches, one being at "Awbury," and another at Miss Nixon's, on East Tulpehocken street. There are also exceedingly fine specimens at George L. Harrison's, on West School House lane; at William Heft's, on Main street; at "Fernhill," and at places elsewhere, too many to name.

By George Redles my attention was directed to a large dogwood (*Cornus Florida*) growing near Queen Lane basin, and there true to life, between the basin and Midvale avenue, may be seen a notable specimen 1½ feet in diameter by 20 feet high, with a spread of 20 feet, and here are two sassafras trees (*Sassafras officinalis*) 2 feet in diameter by 40 feet high, both notable plants, one, however, surpassing the other in form. These are remarkable plants, and stand on historic ground, once part of "Carlton."

Here the army of Washington was encamped, and here during an encampment of the Civil War Joseph Meehan, botanist and horticulturist, active among us, first did "picket duty." Here also is a tulip poplar, 4 feet in diameter and 100 feet high, not equal to Wakefield's notable specimen, but yet a plant of great merit.

We have many superior tulip poplars, one being at "Woodside," Edward T. Steel's residence on West School House lane, 4 feet in diameter and 100 feet high; another on John Wagner's grounds on the same lane being 5 feet in diameter and 60 feet high. There are also several fine tulip poplars at Thomas MacKellar's, on Shoemaker's lane, but the finest specimen here, like the Blair linden at Main street and Walnut lane, has been despoiled.

At "Torworth," the residence of Justus C. Strawbridge, and also at "Blathewood," Joseph S. Lovering's place adjoining, we have very fine specimens of hemlock (*Tsuga canadensis*), as indeed we have in many parts of Germantown, but our finest hemlock trees are in the Wissahickon, where almost the entire southern bank of its romantic stream is fringed by this refreshing tree, and wherein are groups or groves above Kitchen's or

Garsed's lane, above Allen's lane, at Devil's Pool, beside Megargee's dam, and near Rex avenue, plants ranging from 1½ to 2 feet in diameter and from 60 to 80 feet in height. Also near Rex avenue bridge is a specimen hemlock of graceful proportions, having a trunk 2½ feet in diameter and rising to a height of 100 feet.

Among our most interesting plants are the native "Jersey pines," which appear sparingly about Germantown. With us are two varieties, that on School House lane, opposite Gypsy lane, and others in the same neighborhood extending to the mouth of the Wissahickon, are technically known as *pinus inops*.



[Hemlock Glen](#)

At Walnut lane and Wissahickon avenue is a specimen of *pinus rigida* one foot in diameter and 30 feet high. At James A. Mason's, near Upsal Station, is a group of *pinus inops*. At Thomas' Mill road on the Wissahickon, and eastward on the same road in the open above Towanda street, are from one

to two hundred *pinus rigida*, interesting survivors of a flora supplanted. On Stenton avenue, near Bethesda Home, we have an isolated group of *pinus inops*, and at County Line road and Limekiln pike, also on Mt. Airy avenue near Main street are solitary specimens of the same species.

The Wissahickon is covered by numerous valuable plants, but of these a majority is too densely crowded to develop to the best advantage. Several years ago Thomas Meehan in Meehan's Monthly, asked for data of sassafras trees, the text-books and general information agreeing that the average height of mature specimens of this plant to be 30 feet. At "Solitude" and at the "Indian Mound," on E. W. Clark's grounds, School House lane, there are specimens rising to a greater than this height, and at Tulpehocken and Musgrave streets were twin specimens, one now surviving, exceeding this height, and finely formed. Near the "Suicide's Grave," north of Rabbit lane, George Redles informed me there is a specially fine specimen. In the Wissahickon, near Thorp's lane, I measured a slender specimen 80 feet in height, but the finest plants of this species I know were those measured for me by Joseph Heacock, two plants growing near Media, each three feet in diameter and 80 feet high.

About home we have numerous and exceedingly fine specimens of juniper (*juniperus virginiana*). Almost wherever one goes these may be observed—along the borders of Wissahickon, at "Bummers' Cave" on Stenton avenue, on Chew street north of Johnson street, a place known to Ellwood Johnson as "Vinegar Hill," and at Tulpehocken street and Wingohocken creek. This latter tree has a trunk 3 feet in diameter and is 35 feet high. A short time ago it was a healthy, beautiful specimen, but now it is partly or wholly dead, a plant when in its prime approached in my knowledge only by two like it which grow on Sumneytown pike, near "Indian Creek Meeting." At Roberts Le Boutillier's on East Washington lane, and elsewhere near, there are many other specimens worthy of record, but space and time details and elaboration forbid.

The deep frost of last winter played havoc with many plants, partly or wholly destroying box, ivy and other evergreens not usually affected. The celebrated evergreen magnolia (*magnolia grandiflora*) at Lippincott's, Broad and Sansom streets, Philadelphia, entirely dropped its leaves; in many ponds all the fish were killed, and losses in other directions one may not yet undertake to estimate. Untouched, however, we have many box-

bordered garden walks, such as may be seen at "White Cottage," at "Grumblethorpe," at "Wyck," at Spring Bank, at C. M. Bayard's, on upper Main street; formal designs set in green like those at Robert S. Newhall's, Main and Gorgas streets; but the most elaborate and most perfect of our box borders are those adorning the garden of George C. Thomas, at Blue Bell Hill, protected by beautiful hedges of osage orange, arbor vitae and neatly clipped hemlock.

I never pass "Spring-bank" without thinking of John Welsh, its late and honored owner. Here I often saw him walking "in the cool of the day" under the shade of the "glorious" trees which line the front of the estate, and, always excepting Wyck, there is not to me in Germantown a more delightful spot. Here we have already noted a few plants, and we shall stop only to look at a perfect tulip poplar, 3 feet in diameter at trunk, with branches rising to 80 feet, a tree vouched for by Martin Constable, the gardener, as "planted by John Welsh himself," also here is a specimen oak now 20 feet high, the acorn producing which N. Dubois Miller told me was brought from Jerusalem and here grown. In this direction we shall now go no further, but will southward turn, and by way of Main street, which we left at Stenton, proceed to a conclusion. Naglee's and "Joe Nafle's" we shall pass, and the Loudoun pines we have already noted.

Since the days of John Hart progress has here forced its way, and many fine plants, including those on the adjoining grounds of James S. Huber, have retreated before its irresistible advance, and the great tree on the hill equipped with a swing, like "Green's Meadow," implanted in the memory of every "Smearsburg" girl and boy of the last generation, is gone forever. Toland's and Wagner's and Henry's are holding out "like grim death," but it is only a question of time when "Wayne Junction" shall overwhelm them.

It is a pity I have often thought that fruit trees are not more often planted for shade, and native sweet-scented flowering plants for bloom, in a measure to bring the best of orchards and woods to home, and thus more directly beauty and utility combine. Our wood plants without exception may be readily grown if removed at a suitable time and properly planted, and I have never had failure in growing laurel (*kalmia latifolia*), arbutus (*epigaea repens*), and other of our native plants considered difficult to transplant.

Those of us familiar with Main street and Cheltenham avenue 25 years ago may remember "Tinker" Frey's famous swamp magnolia (*magnolia glauca*). This is no more, but we have now at George Redles' on Wister street; at Dr. Herman Burgin's on West Cheltenham avenue; near Christ's Church rectory on West Tulpehocken street; fine specimens of this common in New Jersey swamps, but rare in cultivation, plant.

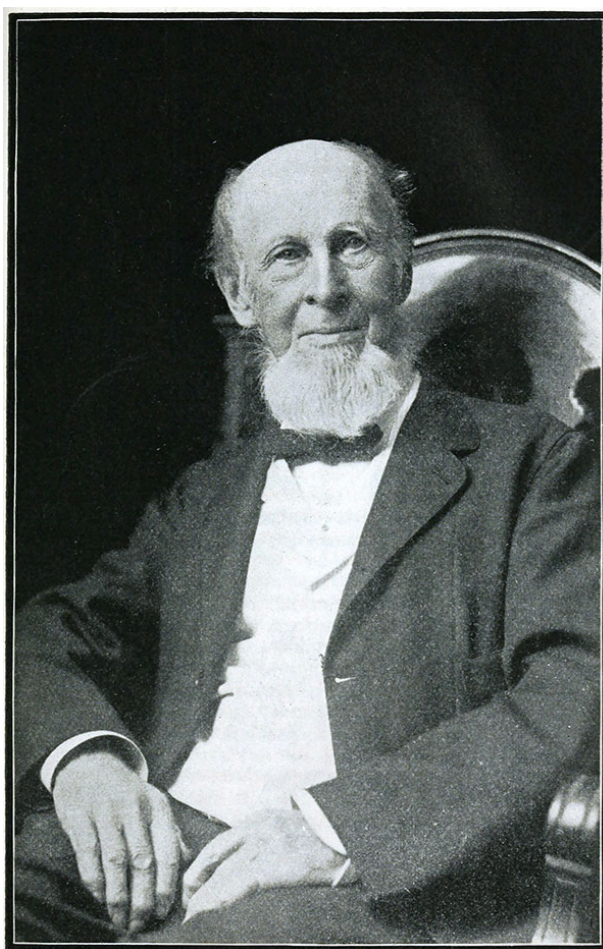
Virginian fringe tree, perfectly hardy, and a very beautiful plant in bloom, although we have several fine specimens, is not common enough in gardens, exceptions not subject to this criticism being conspicuous and notable plants on the grounds of Dillwyn Wistar, Wayne street near Coulter street; Samuel Emlen, Coulter street near Greene street; and Charles M. Bayard, Main street near Carpenter lane. Fringe tree appears spontaneously as far north as the southern counties of New Jersey, and several years ago it was found by Joseph Meehan in the woods near Millville, though before this it had been collected in the same district by Dr. J. B. Brinton. These, with Judas tree (*cercis canadensis*), elder-berry (*sambucus canadensis*) and our native dog-woods in variety, are but a few of many worthy native plants, but enough, I hope, to direct attention to the subject.

A creeping yew (*taxus adpressa*) appears in front of "Conyngham House" or "Hacker House," Main street, opposite Brighthurst street, but is not equal to the famous plant once at Upsala, yet, however, there is a most beautiful specimen of this rare evergreen in the garden of Edward Hacker on Wister street. On grounds to the rear of Conyngham House are several valuable plants for data of which I am indebted to Miss Howell.

Here was one of "the first wild flower gardens" of later Germantown, containing plants from many parts of the United States, but a garden of which only a trace now remains. Here also is "the finest grove of over-cup oaks (*quercus macrocarpa*) about, so Thomas Meehan always said," "and a specimen of strange weeping oak" (*quercus pendula*).

"Grumblethorpe," one of our most familiar homes, is now before us, and its plants are second only to its other possessions. Its occupant and owner is Charles J. Wister, to whom credit earned fully given would seem but empty flattery. Here all his long life lived Charles J. Wister the father, a man whom his neighbor, John Jay Smith, pronounced "the greatest botanist living," and here amidst the sanctity of its associations lives the son, a most worthy

successor. Quoting from an article written several years ago by William E. Meehan, which is sufficiently full for our purpose, there is growing at "Grumblethorpe" "a number of interesting trees, among them three old pear trees, two late Catherine and one sugar pear. There are records to show that these trees are about 150 years old. The sugar pear, which still bears abundantly, is 50 or 60 feet high, and has a girth of six feet. An aged ivy has completely overgrown the trunk and has climbed almost to the topmost branches. A very fine specimen of the famous larch of the Alps, familiar to every student of Swiss Alpine scenery, is also growing on these grounds. This tree, knotted and gnarled with age, has a trunk 5½ feet in circumference, and the tree is probably the finest of its kind around the city."



[Charles J. Wister](#)

A Japanese Ginko tree, which was among the first importations, is also among the curiosities of the Wister place, and, it may be well to add, this is

the first recorded ginko in America to fruit. "About 1830 Charles J. Wister planted one of the first ailanthus (*ailanthus glandulosus*) brought from China. This is one of the most rapid growers of any known tree, and has attained a height of over 70 feet, and has a girth of 12 feet 2 inches."

Here also is a rare specimen of papaw (*asimina triloba*), a tree equaled only by one of the same kind at "Wyck," one foot in diameter by 40 feet high. "A gray poplar (*populus alba*), introduced about the latter part of the last century from Italy, is also growing in Mr. Wister's grounds. Its trunk measures 10 feet 4 inches, and its branches cover a great area of ground."

When we remember that the old fruit trees of "Grumblethorpe" have lived through the busiest life of our town, and yet bear as they did at a time when Christopher Saur in a building close by printed pamphlets and books now highly prized, we may well halt for a moment of reverential meditation, not for the trees and their produce, but for the power which gave them life, which sustained them, and which has given them to us. Interesting trees the garden of "Grumblethorpe" suggest, are the Chancellor pear, which originated on the grounds of William Chancellor, School House lane, adjoining Germantown Academy, and the original Keiffer pear, produced by Peter Keiffer at his nursery on Livezey's lane, west of Wissahickon creek.

While in the vicinity of Germantown Academy, let us notice there a beautiful specimen of blood-leaved maple (*acer J. atropurpureum*), and also one of equal worth on the grounds of Miss Jane E. Hart, diagonally opposite.

These plants are very fine though small,—but superior specimens may be noted at Dr. James Darrach's, Greene street, near Harvey street,—and at Mrs. Thomas W. Evans', Cliveden avenue and Main street, the latter our representative plant.

Thanks to Meehans' nurseries, we have many fine specimens of this showy tree about Germantown, and among a number known to us one of the best is on the grounds of William Rotch Wister, Wisteria avenue. Also in the garden of Samuel Emlen, West Coulter street, among other rare plants is the most beautiful specimen of cut-leaved maple (*acer J. dissectum* a.) I have ever seen.

Passing the residence and one-time garden of the “annalist” John Fanning Watson, we now turn in Penn street to visit “Ivy Lodge,” the home of John Jay Smith, whose long, useful life was here lived, where much of his best work was done, and from whence he departed to the habitations of the “just made perfect.” “Ivy Lodge” is of interest in many ways, but we shall stop only to mention a sun-dial with a noted inscription associated with Stenton, and one of two original “constable boxes” which once did service for the “borough,” the other box being preserved at Manheim,—and present a few plants. Both dial and box are conspicuous objects in the garden, and surrounding them are some of the rarest shrubs and trees in our midst. Far more than I am here able to give, credit is due Miss Elizabeth P. Smith, a daughter of John J. Smith. At “Ivy Lodge” is a specially fine specimen of weeping beech (*fagus H. var. pendula*), a memorial red oak (*quercus rubra*) planted by Miss Smith’s mother, and an immense black oak (*quercus nigra*). Also here once grew a notable juniper (*juniperus squarrata*), and several specimens of *araucaria*.

Miss Smith told me her father many times here tried to raise *araucarias* (*araucaria imbricata*) in the open, but never succeeded in keeping them over three years, this much being “considered quite an achievement.” In England *araucarias* of great height are quite common, so I doubt not the length and severity of our winters is responsible for the plant’s non-existence in our gardens. At “Ivy Lodge” are several fine *mahonias* (*mahonia aquifolium*) of 35 years’ growth, and with the exception of a small specimen growing on the grounds of Edward Hacker, on Wister street, here is the only cedar of Lebanon (*cedrus libani*) to my knowledge growing strictly within the town limits. This is a fine plant about 25 feet in height, and is one of two memorial trees planted in 1852 by John Jay Smith and John Granville Penn, the latter the last of the “proprietor’s” line, in honor of William Penn and James Logan. The “William Penn” tree, planted by a descendant of James Logan, is the plant we may see. The James Logan tree planted by a descendant of William Penn, is no more, having gone the way of “all the earth.”

Until a few years ago there was on the grounds of Colonel Galloway C. Morris, on East Tulpehocken street, a very fine cedar of Lebanon, but this to make room for improvements was destroyed. A “cut” of this plant, however, survives, and with a description may be seen in Vol. I, page 39, of

Meehans' Monthly. Our best and most notable cedars of Lebanon stand in North Laurel Hill Cemetery, and these grown under the care of John Jay Smith are said not to be excelled in America.

I wonder how many who pass up and down Main street, or who visit the Friends' Library, notice the trees at "Friends' Meeting." To me these are always a delight, and I love to look back into the spacious, restful grounds, for here and wherever these "meetings" are is a picture of peace. We all are apt to know more about "green hills" far away than of those immediately before us, for the things at hand often appear ordinary, while those heard of or seen under unusual conditions are rated by an exalted measure.

Walking in the Wissahickon upon two occasions with men of travel, I asked, "Did you ever see a more beautiful place?" One answered, "It is very much like the scenery of New Zealand, but it is better." Another said, "I have traveled throughout Europe, and the only place that will compare at all with it is the Trossachs in Scotland, but in extent it is insignificant compared to this." Henry Carvill Lewis, who "circled the globe" before attaining his "majority," told me in all his travels he saw nothing that in his estimation approached the beauty of the Wissahickon, and others who have traveled far and who lived long abroad have told me "the Wissahickon is incomparable."

So we may know much about "Bartram's cypress," a plant 9 feet in diameter and 120 feet high, while we may not have noticed the beautiful cypress at "Fairfield;" the specimen at David Peltz's, on Nicetown lane; the exceedingly fine specimen 2 feet in diameter and 80 feet high at James E. Caldwell's, on Manheim street; specimens at Henry's, Main street, opposite Fisher's lane; at David Hinkle's, on Main street, near Penn street; at "Ivy Lodge;" at Vernon; at Town Hall Square; at several points on West Walnut lane, at Pomona; and the group of three very fine cypress trees we passed at Friends' grounds.

There are many other fine cypress trees with us, but our most noted ones are on Main street, above Washington lane, where at Ellwood Johnson's is a group of three trees of unusual height, and one solitary plant 5 feet in diameter by 100 feet high, conspicuous by its size. These plants grow upon "Honey Run," on ground once owned by Peter Keyser, whose son of the same name, a "preacher" and tanner, brought them from South Carolina,

and under his direction about the year 1800 were here planted by Israel Haupt, so Miss Elizabeth R. and Ellwood Johnson informed me.

At the Deshler-Morris home, owned and occupied by Elliston P. Morris, is one of our finest gardens, possessing several of our largest and finest trees. Mr. Morris wrote me:

“The exact age of some of my fine old trees is uncertain, the family tradition is that some of them were planted by my grandfather, or members of his family. I doubt not some of the older trees were there when it was President George Washington’s residence during the yellow fever epidemic of 1793. The great storm two years ago with its wind and sleet sadly spoiled my most attractive trees, and in some cases left me but skeletons of their former beauty, notably a 70-year-old elm tree planted by my father, Samuel B. Morris, which stands in the middle of my grounds.”



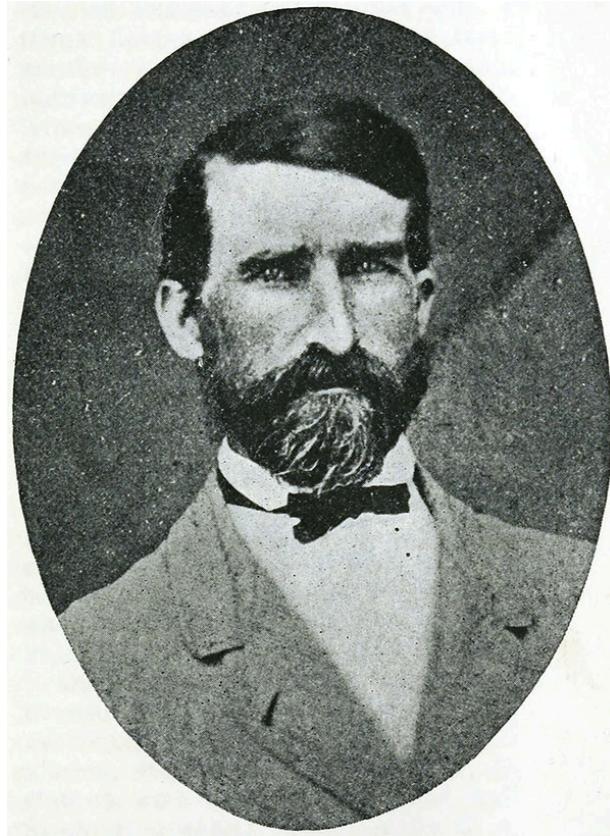
[Elliston P. Morris](#)

Those who view the garden of Mr. Morris wonder at its freshness, and proceeding with its owner:

“The great secret of my lawn is the unbroken expanse of grass, and the planting in conformity with established rules of landscape gardening. I have still some choice specimen trees, notable an immense English horse-chestnut (*aesculus hippocastanum*), with a girth I should think of some 10 feet; a hybrid English walnut (*juglans regia*) and butternut (*juglans cinerea*) very unusual, about 70 feet high and a girth of say 8 feet; a pretty specimen of the lovely cut-leaved beech (*fagus S. heterophylla*); a 70-year-old magnolia glauca, a fine box tree (*boxus arborescens*), and some 100-year-old box-bushes (*boxus sempervirens*), and a good variety of shrubbery, with its ever changing bloom.”

With us are many exceptional gardens, and these, with the beautiful garden of Mr. Morris, I trust may be presented at another time.

We have also many rare “wild garden plants,” and such native rare and notable plants as Goldie’s spleen-wort, climbing fern, walking fern, Nuttall’s spleen-wort, Scott’s spleen-wort, Wister’s coral plant, obolaria, Adam and Eve plant, cancer root, and others exceedingly scarce and valuable, which we may only in this way refer to.



R. Robinson Scott

On Main street, opposite Armat street, in a house occupied by Edward Manley, a one time preceptor of mine, once lived Christian Lehman, scribener, surveyor, notary public and nurseryman, and here in the old “nursery” is an English walnut to remind us of the first local importer of this valuable tree. The present specimen belongs to a later period, but is doubtless a product of an original planting of surrounding grounds. From a much used advertisement of the Pennsylvania Gazette of April 12, 1768, we learn that there was “to be sold—a choice parcel of well grown young English walnut, as well as pear and apricot, and a curious variety of the best and largest sorts from England of grafted plumb trees fit for transplanting this spring or next fall, as well as a great variety of beautiful double hyacinth roots and tulip roots, next summer season, and most other things in the flower or fruit nursery way, by Christian Lehman.”

“Vernon,” although its native charms vanished with its open stream, meadow, spring-house and protecting shrubbery, yet preserves much to hold and interest us. The ground now covered by Vernon include the estate of Melchior Meng and part of that of Henry Kurtz, both plant lovers

possessing fine gardens, which were enriched by cultivations of Matthias Kin, a celebrated plant collector.

Here is the locally known “Meng’s magnolia” (*magnolia macrophylla*) procured by Kin, the first magnolia of its kind cultivated in North America, and here are oak and hemlock trees planted by John Wister in the early part of the last century. Several noted trees once here have gone. One was an immense buttonwood with a trunk having a diameter of 5 feet; another was a weeping willow (*salix babylonica*) located near the spring-house, and others were a large horse-chestnut which shaded the front of Kurtz house, and a large linden (*tilia Americana*) once prominent on the street before the door of Melchior Meng. Many doubtless may recall Meng’s house as “Oliver Jester’s tin shop,” until a few years ago standing on Vernon’s southern front.

Old gardens, and the grapes of which Pastorius wrote have gone, but we have in new Germantown, gardens superior to any of olden time, and I warrant the 8-inch diameter grape vine-trunks of middle Wissahickon are equal to any the “founder” ever saw. So, too, the two gardens of Dr. Christopher Witt are no more, and there is nothing surviving to suggest them.

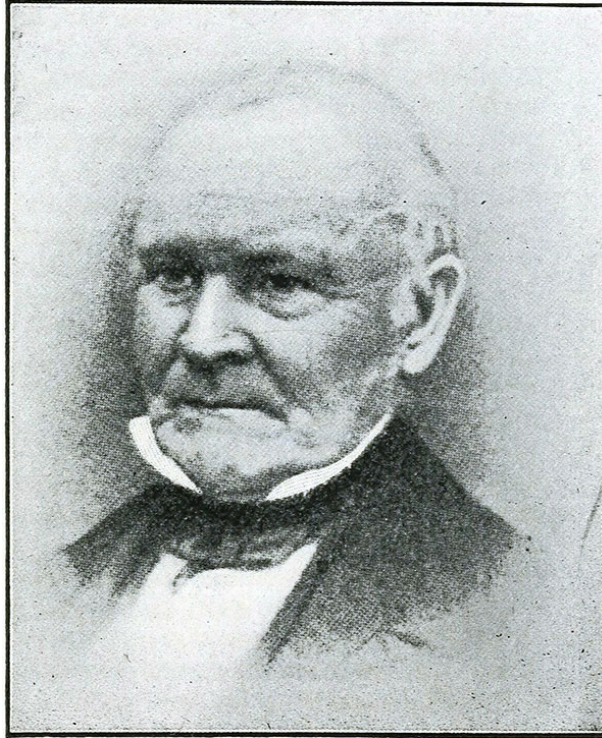
On the Geissler-Warner tract, part of which was also once occupied by Dr. Witt, whereon also he had his first garden, stands St. Michael’s P. E. Church, and on its rear chancel wall is an ivy recently re-planted by E. A. Frey. This plant, carefully transferred from a former position, is a hardy “English ivy” brought originally from Sir Walter Scott’s “Abbotsford” by Dorsey Cox, and was here planted under the direction of the late beloved rector, Dr. John K. Murphy.

At this place also grew a white mulberry tree (*morus alba*) of local celebrity, one of many which sprang up in this neighborhood, the parent tree being at the “cocoonery,” Hermann and Morton streets. Although Dr. Philip Syng Physick, nor his son Philip—who was never a doctor—had any direct connection with this tree, it is justly prized, and I am pleased that in the form of a “Canterbury chair,” made by George Redles, it now occupies a prominent position in the chancel of the church, for beyond these associations, it was grown in the Warner burying ground, where was laid the remains of the Warners, Daniel Geissler, Dr. Christopher Witt, and

perhaps John Kelpius, all Mystics and early botanists, and we have before us a memorial sanctified by the blood it contains.

Though the Warner ground mulberry was a foundling, we have on the original “multicaulis” grounds where Philip Physick lived a solitary specimen of mulberry of unusual size, 3 feet in diameter by 40 feet high, now in bloom, to remind us of a “South Sea bubble” burst, which troubled the investors of a generation past.

Among the noted trees of Germantown was a pecan once standing on the grounds of Dr. William R. Dunton, and which was removed after the erection of the First Methodist Church. This tree was grown from one of several nuts which Thomas Nuttall brought from Arkansas and presented to his friend, Reuben Haines, a prominent officer of the Philadelphia Academy of Natural Sciences, and at whose home in Germantown he was a frequent guest. The nut which produced Doctor Dunton’s tree was given by Reuben Haines to his neighbor, Daniel Pastorius, and two nuts were planted in his own garden, all developed to plants of maturity, but the trees at “Wyck” died, while the Pastorius tree reached large proportions, bore fruit, and it is to be regretted that a specimen of so much interest could not have been preserved.



[Thomas Nuttall](#)

In many respects a pecan (*carya olivaeformis*) resembles a hickory (*carya tomentosa*), a tree whose name occupies an important place in the early records of Germantown. From our Township line boundaries the ancient “hickories” have disappeared, and I shall refer only to a notable one which stood on Baynton street, west of Church lane, a tree Thomas MacKellar described as “the finest hickory” he ever saw.

“Wyck” throughout the history of Germantown has been conspicuous, and I regret that present bounds will not permit us to enlarge upon it. To this attractive spot came the most noted naturalists of the last century, and following in the path of generous culture came Lafayette, who in the year 1825 was given here a public reception, which is distinctly remembered by Robert Thomas and Joseph Murter, honored citizens already referred to, who attended it. At “Wyck” is growing a Spanish chestnut (*castanea vesca*) raised from a tree whose parent nut was planted by Washington at Belmont for Judge Richard Peters. Also here is a white walnut (*juglans cinerea*) grown from a tree planted by Lafayette at Belmont, upon his “farewell visit” to America. Many of us may remember it was an immense tree standing on “Wyck” ground, and afterwards in the centre of the street almost opposite “The Barn,” which gave to Walnut lane its name. This

walnut for many years was permitted to keep its place, but in due time became a prey to expediency.



Wyck

Likewise it was a noted oak which gave name to a familiar “east-side” lane, and the circumstances attending, were almost identical with those serving the Walnut lane dedication.

Among plants rare, though not rare plants, are several which have always puzzled me that they are not more general in cultivation. One of these is tamarisk (*tamarix gallica*), a shrub or small tree common enough in other parts, but with us scarce. The finest specimen of this plant we have is one 8 inches in diameter, rising with a bushy head to a height of 16 feet, and growing in the garden of Mrs. Frank Cooley, 106 Hermann street. Ordinarily tamarisk is of a thin, straggling habit, but responding to care and liberal pruning this plant shows a remarkably heavy, vigorous growth, as a cut, page 173 of volume 12, Meehans’ Monthly, fairly illustrates.

On our way northward, let us as we pass Charles Megargee’s mansion, now the home of a popular club, recall a rare oriental spruce recorded by

William E. Meehan. Impersonality in writing is often its greatest strength, but the credit for a large amount of city history presented by Mr. Meehan I should like to see justly given, for much that has appeared and repeatedly reappeared belongs to him. The oriental spruce (*picea orientalis*) once here was considered a remarkably fine one, and belonged to the “most northern growing of all the pine tree family.” This specimen was brought to Philadelphia “by Engineer George W. Melville on his return from the famous De Long expedition,” the specimen being secured “on an island near the mouth of the Lena river.”

Among our scarce plants is persimmon (*diospyros Virginiana*), though why this should be I do not know, for outside our territory, and especially in the neighborhood of the Perkiomen Valley, it is one of the most common of trees. At Stenton; on Abbotsford avenue near James A. Wright’s place; in the Wissahickon, near “Livezey’s Mills;” near Rabbit lane and County line, we have meritorious if not great persimmons; and at Miss Hocker’s, Main street above Washington lane; also at Joseph C. Channon’s, Main street, above Pastorius street, we have at each place two specimens, noteworthy because being directly upon our main highway they serve to remind us of farm days and the simple character of our one-time village. Here, too, at “Channon’s,” under the care of Miss Amelia R. Wood, is a lusty Japanese persimmon (*diospyros kaki*) which never fails to fruit. Also here, as well as at Miss Elizabeth R. Johnson’s near-by, are quince, pear and apple orchards, survivors of ancient days, blossoming as of old.

Townsend Ward, with others before him, and followed by Judge Samuel W. Pennypacker, have given accounts of a great but almost unknown man who had the confidence to address Cromwell upon his plans, a religious writer of wide influence, the founder of a successful community, which existed nearly 200 years before that of the more widely known Brook Farm of New England. This man was Peter Cornelius Plockhoy, and his colony was located on the Delaware river, where the town of Lewes now is. Ward records: “In 1694 there came to Germantown an old man and his wife. He was blind and poor, and his name was Cornelius Plockhoy, the founder and last survivor of the Mennonite colony broken up 30 years before at the Hoorn Kill by Sir Robert Carr. The good people of Germantown took pity on him;” and continuing with Judge Pennypacker, “they gave him the citizenship free of charge.” They set apart for him at the end street of the

village by Peter Klever's corner a lot 12 rods long and one rod broad whereon to build a little house and make a garden; in front of it they planted a tree. Jan Doeden and William Rittenhouse were appointed to take up "a free will offering" and to have the house built.

I refer to this because Plockhoy, more than he is, should be identified with Germantown, because a tree in this early life of the colony was considered of sufficient importance to name, and also because this house and tree stood upon Kyser's lane within sight of the homestead owned and occupied by Miss Elizabeth R. Johnson, in whose charming garden situated at the northwest corner of Main street and Washington lane, we shall stop for awhile to "sit at her feet" while she entertains us with accounts of her historic plants. Among the rare treasures here is a fine Persian lilac (*syringa persica*) planted in 1771, which continues vigorous and spreads its sweetness upon the receptive air. A curious fig (*ficus carica*) here is the development of a shoot which for 4 years after the removal of the parent tree did not appear, but is now, as figs go, a stately plant. Here also on the southern exposure of the mansion is the first wisteria (*wisteria speciosa*) planted in Germantown, and one of the first planted in America, a plant of immense proportions, and whose numerous runners overspreading two near-by trees weighted them to earth.



Johnson Homestead

Many fine wisteria plants we have, and at Ellwood Johnson's fascinating retreat adjoining there is a most beautiful specimen; another is at "Grumblethorpe;" another at William Rotch Wister's on Wisteria avenue, and yet another at Dr. Herman Burgin's on West Chelten avenue; also at David McMahon's on East Chelten avenue are two handsome wisterias grown as standards. All these are notable plants, and conspicuous among an innumerable company which help beautify our town.

At the Johnson homestead are several fine box trees planted in the year 1800, and these bring to mind other superior box trees; plants on Hermann street, near Baynton street; at Hacker house, on Main street; at Vernon, and at many other points in our territory.

At Ellwood Johnson's we shall halt for a moment to partake of his sparkling spring water, and note a pear tree of Revolutionary days which yet spreads its branches over a charming spring-house. Here until the storm which overthrew Christ Church steeple, stood an old willow (*salix babylonica*) with a trunk 5½ feet in diameter, and one of the first weeping willow trees planted in America, a notable specimen which outliving its strength was

felled by the great wind of the storm referred to, but now a scion from its roots has risen to preserve its memory.

Also here among many notable plants is a fine specimen of the rare clammy locust (*robinia viscosa*), and the largest hazelnut (*corylus Americana*) I have ever seen, a plant of 20 feet in height, and covering a large area.

Passing Concord School, its nature-loving pupils, George Lippard and William E. Meehan, with other associations of interest to plant students, we halt at "Pomona Grove" to present a plant which should not be forgotten, for "Pomona" and its charms are now a memory. At the northeast corner of what is now Baynton street and Pomona terrace once stood a yew, which by those competent to judge was considered remarkable. No one has been able to definitely state where this tree came from, nor when it was planted. All agree that it was a mature imported plant and was placed at "Pomona" by Col. Thomas Forrest. There need be no mystery, however, for it is well known a yew grows rapidly for 20 or more years, more slowly for a hundred years, after which period it exists in a practically stationary condition.

Prof. Thomas Meehan pronounced the Pomona yew the finest he had ever seen, and his ripe knowledge and wide travels gave a distinct value to the opinion. This plant was in perfect condition, covered a circle of 13 feet diameter, and stood at a height of 20 feet.

"Alas, that vandal hands should tear away
The ancient landmarks dear to other days,
And spoil the verdurous temples in a day,
Which nature took so many years to raise!"

It is to be forever regretted that the efforts of our Germantown Horticultural Society to secure this gem for Market Square failed, for it rather than objectionable intrusions now there, would better serve the purposes for which the block was set apart.

We have, however, near Market Square in the garden of Elliston P. Morris, a small, but perfect and very beautiful specimen of English yew, identical in variety with the plant so unfortunately lost.

Continuing—we pass Miss Arrott’s select school, which was once a barn, and Leonard Stoneburner’s house and farm, he an active citizen, whose pride lay rather in the speed of his horses than in “crops” and trade and politics, all of which claimed a large share of his attention; also passing Naaman K. Ployd’s garden, and his numerous plants of more than local interest—we soon reach “Cliveden,” first occupied as a country seat by Chief Justice Chew in the year 1763. This is the battleground’s centre, and is sacred because of the men who died there; but while appreciating this, let us work and pray for a time when war shall be considered a crime, and the taking of human life for any cause, murder. At “Cliveden” there are now no plants of the Revolutionary period, and many of its finest shrubs have been planted within my memory.

“Growing close against the Chew mansion a beautiful rose of Japan. It is certainly at least 75 years old, and has delighted all who have seen it by the quality and beauty of its large red blossoms,” so noted William E. Meehan. Mrs. Chew wrote me: “There were a number of magnificent English elms, a row along the front of the place near the street, extending as far as Upsal street, and another row along Cliveden street.”

Near the barn there is at present an elm (*ulmus campestris*), a sole representative of the trees indicated. The street “trees were killed by wanton boys when the family temporarily left the place about 40 years ago,” and by the fathers I doubt not of the “Dog-towners,” who stoned every Rittenhouse School boy of my own class reckless enough to venture alone into the reserved precincts of “Beggarstown.” Here is a beautiful specimen of European larch (*larix Europaea*), and to continue with Mrs. Chew, “the tulip poplars on the west side of the house were planted by Blair McClanachan during the few years after the battle that he owned the property. The oak on the lawn in front of the house was planted about 70 years ago by one of the family.”

The pine tree (*pinus rigida*) on the front lawn “may be accounted for in the following way, I think, although I do not positively know. Mr. Chew, the son of the Chief Justice, owned a number of very fine farms in New Jersey, and his tenants there were of the same family for generations, and they were on the most kind and friendly terms with Mr. Chew. I imagine that this tree when very small may have been brought as a gift to Mr. Chew by one of his tenants, and there planted by Mr. Chew himself.”

Surviving on Upsal street is a companion pine, which from its position gives strength to this opinion, for these trees appear to have been twins planted in “Cliveden” equi-distant.



Cliveden

“Upsala,” opposite, which we all know well by name, possesses several of our finest and most notable plants. Miss Sally W. Johnson, who owns and occupies it, generously gave me an account of its rare home plants, which we may now only present in outline. Among these plants were grapes planted and cared for by Dr. Johnson, a very large white flowering camellia, a white flowering sweet jasmine, a laurestinas, a daphne, not equal to the one which Miss Ann Chew had in her hall by the front window. Of her garden, Miss Johnson’s account is so interesting that I cannot deny myself the pleasure of quoting. In it “there were in summer Bordeaux lilies, and varlotta purpurea, a handsome red clustered lily, and agapanthus with their odd shade of lavender blue; funkias, vincas, oriental poppies in garden beds, and the ‘York and Lancaster’ rose still blooms, though it is a curious

dwarf. The Marie Louise, a sweet light pink rose, has lived on all through the garden for I am sure the past hundred years. I try to replace the trees or plants that have died. There was once a double row of white Hawthorn to the Johnson street entrance. The red berries were so bright, and made a charming English decoration for Christmas. A double pink hawthorne was a very fine tree.”

“The fringe tree was an old favorite, arching gracefully over the middle walk, and when gone was replaced by another, and a group of tartarian honeysuckle is still blooming every spring after the daffodils and cowslips and double low buttercups with their mottled shiny leaves, periwinkles and lilies of the valley were in every shady spot, and the late summer was gorgeous with phlox—the hardy—and Drummondii, larkspurs, tritoma, trumpet vine, and the like.”

Though many of “Upsala’s” best trees are no more, here yet are several of which we may be justly proud. The once well-known creeping yew is gone, and the silver fir planted in 1800, which reached 100 feet in height, a plant figured and described in A. J. Downing’s “Landscape Gardening,” was removed several years ago, and a memorial apolinian fir was planted in its place.



[Upsala](#)

Here is a famous American yew, a plant distinct from English yew; a noted catalpa, a dwarf spruce, a handsome tulip-poplar, a number of towering white pines, an exceedingly fine cryptomeria or Japan cedar, which greatly excels specimens at "Fairfield," at Edward Hacker's on Wister street, at Peter Keiffer's on Livezey's lane; and here is a California redwood or "big-tree" (*sequoia gigantea*), a plant now about 25 feet in height, the rarest, and so far as known to me, the only specimen of a size worthy of consideration in Philadelphia. This tree, now showing the effects of last winter's unusual frost, stands directly in front of the mansion, and my prayer is that "Upsala" unaltered, and its owner in health and "perpetual youth," may continue until it attains the proportions of its most illustrious progenitors.

Time presses upon us, so we shall pass rapidly Billmyer house, where are beautiful specimens of locust (*robinia pseudacacia*), walnut and honeylocust (*gleditschia triacanthos*); Peter Leibert house, where are fair Norway spruce, horse-chestnut and silver maple; the Church of the Brethren grounds, where grow four of our finest trees, two larch trees, each 2 feet in

diameter and 60 feet high, and two coffee trees of magnificent development, plants 2 feet in diameter by 80 feet high each; several striking plants of merit at Peter D. Hinkle's; St. Michael's Lutheran Church grounds, where is a superb specimen of Irish yew (*taxus*, var. *Hibernica*), resembling, but in beauty far exceeding, similar plants at St. Vincent de Paul's Church, and Lower Burying Ground; Phil-Ellena, the one-time residence of George W. Carpenter, whose garden of home gardens, if not the greatest, was at least the one most widely known, but its rare plants are now distributed and its notable trees in the main leveled to accommodate "Pelham," a late product of capital and change.

At George Hesser or William M. Bayard house, opposite, is a number of fine box-bordered walks, an impressive linden resembling the linden in Concord Burying Ground, and a picturesque white pine, but these without further mention we shall neglect to stop briefly at Joseph Meehan's, on Pleasant street, and at Meehan's nursery on Main street, the latter once located at the southeast corner of Meehan avenue, where numerous plants now beautifying home streets and gardens were first grown.

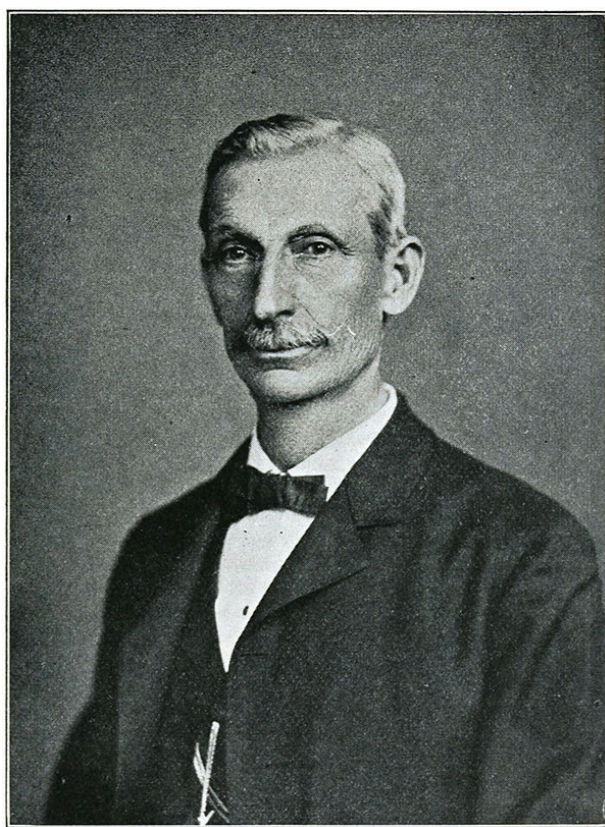
Among Joseph Meehan's "wild plants" is a handsome aster, discovered by this botanist near Gettysburg, Pa., a plant which for several years has been growing in his garden. As yet the "authorities" have not decided upon a name, so we shall present it as aster Meehani.

Here also is a specimen of the rare Franklin tree (*gordonia pubescens*), and with the exception of a like specimen at Meehan's nurseries, and another near Horticultural Hall, also one raised by William De Hart and now growing near Lansdowne, it is the finest specimen I know.

In our "Flora," I have referred to the parent of this tree, which was a scion of the plant brought from South Carolina by William Bartram. The original plant, abused at Bartram Garden after the retirement of Colonel Carr, was rescued and revived by William De Hart at his garden on Darby road, where it grew for several years. It was then presented to Joseph Meehan, on whose grounds, its energy spent, it struggled through a precarious existence to an honored death—truly an interesting record of the most remarkable plant in botanical nomenclature.

From Main street nursery Thomas Meehan removed to "Hong's Farm," on Chew street. His partner, William Saunders, located first on Johnson street,

near Greene street, and later took charge of the experimental gardens at Washington. At the Chew street nurseries are many of the choicest and most notable plants in America, specimens from which plates of the “Flowers and Ferns of the United States” were figured; indeed so many “new and rare plants” that I shall leave them, trusting that Joseph Meehan may favor us with a paper upon the same, and at present we shall be content with reference to a few valuable ones I think him likely to ignore—namely, cut-leaved plum (*prunus myrobolana*, var. *dissectum*); *halesia Meehani* or silver-bell, a species of shrub or small tree bearing beautiful white bell-shaped flowers; weeping dog-wood (*cornus* F., var. *pendula*), and rose-flowering dog-wood (*cornus* F., var. *flore rubro*), all distinct varieties originating at these widely known and justly famed nurseries.



Joseph Meehan

I had thought to completely cover our territory, but within the “time limit” this I have found impossible. There are many “estates” of merit with us to which I have not referred, and on them and elsewhere near are many deserving plants and odd growths I should like to introduce and enlarge upon, such as a cherry (*prunus serotina*) of immense proportions, situated

on Fisher's lane, near Lower Burying Ground; a very fine silver-bell tree on the grounds of George W. Russell, Seymour street near Morris street; two beautiful elms on Spencer's Farm, and standing near the site of "Roberts' mill" on Church lane, near Township Line road; the Henry Lenhart memorial stone in Market Square Church grounds, which since the year 1830 has been enveloped by the root growth of a silver maple, and in its vise-like grip is supported vertically; several commemorative trees, emblems of affection, such as the purple beech and white pine trees planted on Greene street near Coulter street by "Dr. Rivinis, a grandson of the botanist for whom Rivinia or rouge plant" was named; and the "Mollie Middleton," "Helen T. Longstreth" and numerous other marked trees in the Wissahickon; an exceedingly fine American aspen on the grounds of Dr. Daniel Karsner, Tulpehocken and Greene streets; a group of large pine trees at Adams street and Washington lane; the wild goose lily treasured by Ellwood Johnson, a unique plant resembling, but quite distinct from *Hemerocallis Flava* of our gardens; a valuable and perfectly formed Norway maple, situated on Chew street, near Washington lane, a tree which always leads its kind in leaf and flower; an immense hawthorn (*crataegus oxyacantha*) on Magnolia street, near Johnson street; individual paulownia (*paulownia imperialis*), catalpa (*catalpa bignonioides*), and smoke trees (*rhus cotinus*) of merit, conspicuous in many places throughout our domain; a celebrated Irish yew once standing beside the Carpenter Mansion at Phil-Ellena; a white oak of remarkable growth showing a trunk 5 feet in diameter, a height of 60 feet, and having an immense limb tapering from 2 feet in diameter, 32 feet long, projecting horizontally for its entire length, and completely spanning Rabbit lane, east of E. Rittenhouse Miller's place; a magnolia, the product of skill if not art, flourishing on James E. Gowen's grounds at Main street and Gowen avenue, a monstrosity formed by the union of a circle of plants drawn together at about 3 feet above the earth and united, rising in a central trunk, reminding one of Alexander Pope and his strange fancies at Twickenham; a curious seat at "The Cherries" at Springbank, naturally supported by the outgrowth of two oak trees,—and near the same spot, a storm-cleft chestnut tree, which strangely has renewed itself; many rare and beautiful magnolias, such as may be seen at Mrs. Taws', West Tulpehocken street, at Thomas Meehan's, at "Wyck," at William Heft's, and in general distribution throughout our territory; "cut-leaved" plants in variety, such as may be seen on Baynton street, near Walnut lane,

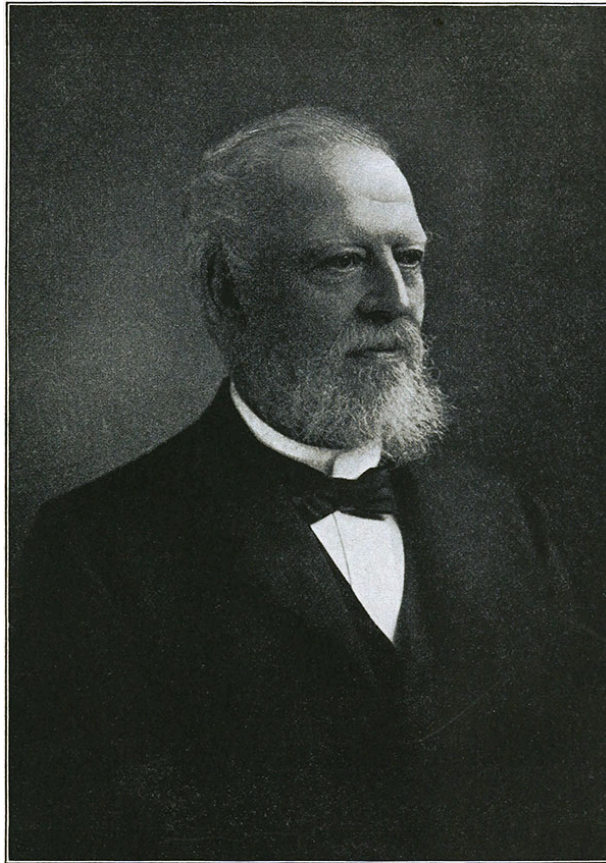
at Cheltenham avenue and Godfrey street, and at many places elsewhere; Kilmarnock willows and “weeping plants” innumerable; rare plants at Miller & Yates’; the celebrated “paragon chestnut” of William L. Schaeffer, a variety of Spanish chestnut (*castanea vesca*) which originated on what is now the Institution for the Deaf and Dumb grounds, and obtained wide celebrity; fern-leaved beech (*fagus*, var. *asplenifolia*) at Edward S. Buckley’s, and weeping beech (*fagus*, var. *pendula*) at C. B. Dunn’s, with another noted one at Thomas C. Price’s, all of Chestnut Hill; Caleb Cope’s garden “grotto” and valuable plants; the “new garden” of John T. Morris on Wissahickon, a botanical garden in every respect save name; and many unique plants stationed throughout the length and breadth of the Wissahickon region.

But among our superabundance it has been possible only to mark a few guide posts to point the way to all who care “to lead or follow” to a possession which in other parts is suggested only by such rich old settlements as Alexandria, West Chester and some New England towns, but not any of which, so far as I have been able to observe, is able to approach the treasure ever present with us. Much that we desire to present we thus are obliged to curtail or ignore, and with one more thought we shall conclude.

When visitors of distinction called upon George W. Childs at “Wootton,” they invariably were requested to plant a tree. The custom is a pleasing one, worthy of imitation, and should be encouraged. Wrote Thomas Meehan: “trees are associated with our dearest memories and most important events.” Abroad memorial and historic trees are so numerous that we refer to them only for illumination, and in our own country we have the “Charter Oak” of Connecticut, the famous “Elm of Cambridge,” and the “Treaty Tree” of Philadelphia. Other trees quite as important, but not so well known, are the “Liberty Tree” of Newport, the mulberry tree of Maryland under which the first settlers met to establish a government, and the plane tree of Burlington, to which New Jersey colonists tied ship before the founding of Philadelphia.

Stop soon we must, and passing many home plants of tender associations, I shall select one, and close with mention of a memorial tree near Kitchen’s bridge in the Wissahickon, a pin oak (*quercus palustris*), planted “Arbor Day, 1903, by the pupils of Andrew G. Curtin Public School in memory of Thomas Meehan, the friend of boys and girls.” No truer words than these

were ever penned, but let us not limit, for Thomas Meehan was a friend to all—the world is better because he lived, and there is no one in Germantown this day who does not enjoy the fruit of his great work.



Prof. Thomas Meehan

So we pass, and although our list of plants is indicative only, and those named but meagrely “presented,” yet we trust enough has been noted to direct attention to the beautiful creations placed before us to enjoy. We have no need to covet or compare, for in a magnificent fullness we have what others have not, and while we envy not nor desire another less, let us for ourselves strive to deserve the favors so bountifully given us, and take lesson, for false accumulations are vanity, so let us spurning the selfishness of the few who ignore the rights of the many, find pleasure in pursuits which no abuse is able to restrict nor monopoly to control, for when schemers and their usurpations are no more, nature incorruptible and unalterable will continue steadfast on her way.

Now as I go about our “village,” developed to a full-fledged town, I rejoice that we have so much for the enjoyment of the many, and so little that is not

as free as our own desires. As of old, our common highway follows its tortuous course, and although peach and weeping willow and lombardy poplar trees of long ago have vanished, other trees of sturdier mould have risen to take their place. Large, substantial houses in the ripeness of age continue with us, but those who built them sleep in our shaded graveyards, and we may decipher their names on bleached and weather-beaten decomposing stone. Lofty trees planted by those who “have gone before,” in “the fullness of time” stand as monuments to them, and as friends to us to shade and protect.

Time “may come, and time may go,” for nature is change, and change nature, but to us “Providence has been very kind,” and the past though hardly pressed, yet dominates the present.

Mansions and plantations justly venerated have become the property of all, and now among us we have “Vernon” and “Stenton,” “Waterview” and “Cliveden” as public parks, not great nor finished as yet, but ours, while behind looming up in the possibilities of “pleasure grounds” is “Fernhill,” and with us forever secure is the peerless Wissahickon.

Though slowly, the character of our town alters, “orders old giving place to new,” but I rejoice that we have so much to remind us of days gone by — “Cliveden” and “Upsala,” “Grumblethorpe” and “Wyck,” to any of which an enforced change would be a catastrophe.

Logan, Huber’s, Spring Alley, “Tinker” Frey’s, Vernon and Chew springs have gone, but Wister, Cope and Johnson springs continue to remind us of rural long ago. Henry’s, Vernon and Methodist lane pumps, once with never-tiring handles traveling uncomplainingly “neath earth and sky” for the public good, have been retired, but “Manheim street pump” unfailingly dispenses to who so e’er will wait. Toll-gate, Conestoga and stage-coach have disappeared from our turnpike road, and the trolley has “followed after,” yet in spite of “all temptation” we cling to the past, and the “Germantown wagon” undaunted waits upon us to do us service.

Change truly is in the air, but there is a remarkable blending of the old with the new. The curse of war has passed from among us, “swords have been beaten into plough-shares, and spears into pruning hooks,” “peace and plenteousness” reign within our borders. No more the cannon’s thundering roar disturbs our homes, and “storied groves of Johnson’s lane, where

Washington the bold led Freedom's sons on British guns in the brave days of old" are free of strife.

Now from many gardens on our "Appian Way" the perfume of blooming plants "maketh glad the heart of man;" native birds frequent, charming with enlivening song, our Main street lawns, and from above, falling upon never-tiring ears, "the great bell still tolls the hours," as one by one they round to remind us of youth and age and the "vast forever," while over the "belgian block," heedlessly perhaps, "the noise of traffic rolls."

Days come and go, the wheel turns. With us, "too soon, too soon, the noon will be the afternoon, to-day be yesterday." "The night cometh" when no man may work. While it is yet day, let us remember those who "planted and watered" that we might benefit, and not forgetting our obligations to them, to ourselves and posterity, let us appreciate and provide, so that generations to come may receive with the increase those blessings so generously showered upon us, that the Germantown of greater opportunity to be, may upon the traditions and heritage preserved and bequeathed, rise to heights not attained, because unknown to us.

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Typos and extraneous punctuation corrected.

Inconsistencies in hyphenation have been left unchanged.

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